

Vectoral Agents 2

Are You Agentic Enough?

1. Cabin Fever	1
<i>Jernej Markelj</i>	
2. Agency and Paralysis in AI Thought Experiments	20
<i>Marianne Gunderson</i>	
3. Cybernetics: (Dis)entangling Ontologies, Epistemologies, and Politics	32
<i>Claudio Celis Bueno</i>	
4. Invasion-as-a-Service: Pluribus and the Intrusive Benevolence of AI	42
<i>Jakko Kemper</i>	
5. Power Bottoming	52
<i>Amy Ireland</i>	
6. AI Slop and Its Discontents	61
<i>Sophie Publig</i>	
Biographies	74

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Cabin Fever

CABIN FEVER

JERNEJ MARKELJ

‘Entering the matrix is no assertion of masculinity, but a loss of humanity’, declares Sadie Plant in the mid-90s, ‘to jack into cyberspace is not to penetrate, but to be invaded.’¹ Her declaration, which comes at the peak of Web 1.0 optimism, predicts the decline of patriarchal order under the hands of emerging networked technologies. The agential subject—the user—, who has always been modelled on the masculine image, no longer exerts mastery and control over its environment when he logs online. Instead, his masculinity, defined by his autonomy, control, and self-determination, is now under siege by fluid and feminizing forces of self-organizing technologies, whose runaway circuits increasingly engulf and emasculate him. The complexity of these self-organizing technologies, Plant observes and predicts, will overthrow the oppressive systems by means of which men have always dominated women, nature, and machines. As machines level the playing field, humanity is stripped of the masculine fantasies of sovereignty and control, in other words, of the very traits that define humanity in the first place.

Plant’s vision of the rise of cyberfeminist machines, which download emancipation automatically, was heavily critiqued from the outset. She was dismissed as naïve and uncritical: as being out of touch with the reality of the technologies that are being assembled, completely overlooking the ways in which these machines mold and pattern the social.² Plant’s slightly more charitable critics interpreted her theories as myth-making: she is ‘merely’ telling an alluring tale so as to shape the way people perceive reality, and thus attempting to call it into existence. Thirty years on, the dominant critiques of our networked technologies paint a picture even further removed from Plant’s techno-optimist vision than the objections her

1 Sadie Plant, ‘The future looms: Weaving women and cybernetics’, *Body & Society*, 1, nr. 3–4 (1995): 60.

2 See Vincent Lê, ‘The Most Radical Philosopher: Putting the Cyber Back in Sadie Plant’s Cyberfeminism’, *Cosmos and History: The Journal of Natural and Social Philosophy* 18(2): 487; and Susanna Paasonen, ‘From cybernation to feminization: Firestone and cyberfeminism’, in Stella Sandford and Mandy Merck (eds) *Further Adventures of the Dialectic of Sex: Critical Essays on Shulamith Firestone*. New York: Palgrave Macmillan US, 2010, p. 96.

contemporaries raised against it. The internet—at this point a hyper-object fully fused with our social fabric—is linked to data extraction, slop and misinformation, dominance of reactionary and manospherian online cultures, exploitative labour practices, and generative models amplifying structural inequalities as well as environmental devastation. There is no denying that the internet as we know it is a constant source of toxicity and exploitation. But is this all there is to it?

Could it be that Plant's posthuman vision of the future is already here, just not very evenly distributed? Is it micro-dosed from place to place? Or perhaps the reality of Plant's self-governing machines remains hidden under the layers of entrenched humanism that are still obscuring our worldview? And if so, is there indeed anything emancipatory about the spontaneity of machinic operations, or do they simply reproduce more of the same old oppressions, or even intensify them? If there are any emancipatory openings, how can they be pried open? Can this be done by users who no longer see themselves as autonomous agents completely in control of technologies deployed to dominate nature, but instead as entities fully immersed in, and therefore dependent on, the world they inhabit? But what if this paradigm shift is already aligned with the logic of the systems that govern us, which are less invested in addressing us as free individuals than handling us as nameless materials for their operations?

This collected volume engages with the issue of intelligent and self-governing technologies to examine the politics of conceptualizing and attributing agency in the age of neural networks. Building on the first volume of *Vectoral Agents*,³ we continue to examine the agential technopolitics of planetary computation, its stacks that connect users with affordances and interfaces, algorithmic architectures and synthetic media, as well as data centers and underwater cables. Within these vast and complex assemblages, the user is no longer an operator, but a cog in the machine, functioning alongside the microtime temporalities of infinite datapoints and vectoral movements, and the geological deep-time of lithium, copper, and other metals and minerals powering our digital infrastructures.⁴ These operations mostly either precede and shape, or completely by-pass, human consciousness, unfolding in what Günther Anders

3 Jernej Markelj and Claudio Celis Bueno (eds), *Vectoral Agents: Power in the Age of Planetary Computation*, Amsterdam: Institute for Network Cultures, 2025.

4 Jakko Kemper, 'Deep time and microtime: Anthropocene temporalities and Silicon valley's longtermist scope', *Theory, Culture & Society* 41, nr. 6 (2024).

calls ‘the world without us’, constituted by recursive circuits of automation coupled with highly distributed and fragmented points of human input.⁵

As no single human agent or group has the bird’s eye view of these heterogeneous socio-technological systems, we are past the point ‘where architects get lost in the pattern’.⁶ Indeed, as Plant claims, ‘self-guiding systems were not in the plan’.⁷ *The Promethean gap*, the interval that separates what humans can create with technologies from our ability to control or even just imagine these operations, continues to escalate.⁸ If humans are indeed animals that invented themselves by using tools, what happens when our technological networks cross a threshold of complexity that begins to overwhelm our all-too-human capacities?⁹ Does the tired interpretative scheme of humans as autonomous agents, who stand in opposition to nature as their rulers, begin to dissolve?

CABIN FEVER

As we argued in the first volume of *Vectoral Agents*, this is clearly not the case. ‘As markets learn to manufacture intelligence’, the story goes, our humanist politics ‘upgrades paranoia, and tries to get a grip’.¹⁰ Amidst the self-perpetuating and interlocking loops of algorithms and capital, the liberal-humanist fiction of individual autonomy and control stubbornly persists. Even though our societies are increasingly organized by meaningless signals and quantitative operators—computer code, market calculations, and stock indices—our institutions continue to address us as free decision-makers, fully in charge of, and responsible for, our destinies.¹¹ The user is locked in a double bind, ‘frozen in place by the impossible contradictory demands of being both embedded inside a planetary society that mediates itself through vast physical connections of information, energy, and matter, and simultaneously asked to realize their potential as a self-sovereign autonomous agent’.¹²

5 See Günther Anders, *The Obsolescence of the Human*, trans. by Christopher John Müller, Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press, 2025.

6 Sadie Plant, ‘Feminisations: Reflections on Women and Virtual Reality’, in Lynn Herschman Leeson (ed.) *Clicking In: Hot Links to a Digital Culture*, San Francisco: Bay Press, 1996, p. 37.

7 Ibid.

8 See Anders, *The Obsolescence of the Human*.

9 See André Leroi-Gourhan, *Gesture and speech*, Cambridge, MA: MIT Press, 1993.

10 Nick Land, ‘Meltdown’, *Cybernetic Culture Unit*, ccru.net/swarm1/h_melt.htm.

11 See Maurizio Lazzarato, *Signs and Machines: Capitalism and the Production of Subjectivity*, trans. Joshua David Jordan, Los Angeles: Semiotext (e), 2014.

12 Benjamin Bratton, *The revenge of the real: Politics for a post-pandemic world*, London: Verso, 2021.

JERNEJ MARKELJ

While each of the five other contributions to this collected volume engages with this tension along different lines, my opening essay picks up on Plant's exploration of agential socio-technological systems as the vectors of feminization. My aim is to examine the masculine resistance to these uprooting and undermining forces, which frustrate the desire for mastery, rationality, and control. This paranoid pushback against the emasculating vectors undermining the performance of masculinity is explored through the figure of the cabin, which I read as the symbol of male self-determination and control. The cabin is thus framed as a technology of self-containment,¹³ a way to shelter oneself against processes of abstraction, deskilling, passivation, and disempowerment, and thus shoring up the fantasy of individual autonomy. Correspondingly, what I term *cabin mentality* concerns ways of thinking, feeling, and acting, which seek to enforce and safeguard the boundaries that separate the allegedly unrestrained subjective interiority from the material forces of the body and its environment. In this way, cabin mentality can be understood as a nervous acknowledgement of agential forces that threaten the fantasy of autonomy, and, at the same time, a pushback against these forces, aiming to reassert this illusive autonomy.

‘To be autonomous is to be self-governing, independent, and not ruled by any external law or force’.¹⁴ To see oneself in this way, as a self-contained mind isolated from the corporeality inhabited by our bodies, is to ignore the multiplicity of flows that ceaselessly pass between them, thus enabling and shaping our capacities to think and act. It is to overlook the embodied relations with the world that constitute and sustain our subjectivities in the first place. Unsurprisingly, this illusion of possessing a free and autonomous mind is more easily sustained by white, heterosexual men than by women and racialised subjects, who are continually made aware of their bodies by patriarchal and racist social systems.¹⁵ This illusion of control can be heightened behind the wheel of a speeding car. A driver, contained by a metal cabin, appears as a self-determined agent who stands in

13 Marie-Luise Angerer, Ingrid Richardson, Hannah Schmedes, and Zoë Sofoulis (eds) *Containment: Technologies of holding, filtering, leaking*, Lüneburg: meson Press, 2024.

14 Langdon Winner, *Autonomous Technology: Technics-out-of-Control as a Theme in Political Thought*, Cambridge, MA: MIT Press, 1978, p. 16.

15 Frida Beckman, ‘Paranoid Masculinity, Or, Toward A New Identity Politics’, *sym-ploke*, Vol. 29, Nr. 1-2, 2021: 236.

opposition to his environment and dominates it through his mastery of the automotive machinery.¹⁶ There is hardly a more masculine image than a lone driver, spiked by the thrill of power, speed, and risk, out on the empty road.

CABIN FEVER

And yet, there is something dated and even folkloric about this image. It represents a world that has not yet been penetrated by the computational infrastructure that increasingly undergirds our daily lives. Today, a car is not simply a mechanical technology, but ‘a habitat organized and narrated by data networks’.¹⁷ As we move further toward driverless technology, the latter gradually ‘decenters the agency and authority of the human pilot from the cockpit and disperses it into ambient networks operating at multiple scales’.¹⁸ In this way, the act of driving no longer enables the projection of being in control by imposing dominance over one’s fate. As a car’s function as masculine technology of self-containment is eroded, the driver becomes increasingly passive, no longer an operator, but a passenger, a patient rather than an agent. There is the anticipation that to some this will ‘prove an unacceptable emasculation or even dehumanization and will be met with violent resistance, and various forms of human-centric identity politics’.¹⁹

Cars and guns are prime examples of technologies ‘that are thought to embody the essence of human mastery’, a mastery that is always primarily masculine.²⁰ As such, they are ‘seen to amplify the human, not contaminate it by mediation and hybridization’.²¹ Cabin mentality, which seeks to protect and uphold the fiction of individual autonomy from the undermining socio-technological influences, thus depends on these *other* technologies and the masculinizing practices they enable. While these tools and devices afford our actions and shape our capacities, their influence is unacknowledged and remains hidden beneath the fantasy of self-determination. It is not unlikely that the near future will see an emergence of ‘a movement to identify human-driven automobiles as a type of “arms” and that the Second Amendment to the United States Constitution,

16 In other words, what is overlooked is the network of relations that make such movement possible in the first place. The act of driving emerges from the ongoing interaction between the affordances of road infrastructure, mechanics of the car, weather conditions, capacities of the driver (which are not innate but shaped through a series of socially organized encounters) etc.

17 Benjamin Bratton, *The stack: On software and sovereignty*, Cambridge, Massachusetts: MIT press, 2016, p. 280.

18 Ibid., p. 344.

19 Ibid.

20 Ibid.

21 Ibid.

now used to shield gun owners from obvious liabilities and to protect their sense of personal dominion, will be flown to keep human beings behind steering wheels'.²² As they protect the masculine sense of integrity and self-containment, these technologies are a site of an intense affective investment, and tampering with them leads to a fervent push-back.²³

CABINS, MICROWORLDS, CLOSED SYSTEMS

Cabin mentality has a long history rooted in the tension between the persisting liberal-humanist idea of autonomous self, and the escalating intricacy of socio-technological systems, which constitute the material conditions that render this concept of the self increasingly untenable. As such, it goes at least as far back as the emergence of Western modernity. Cabin mentality can already be found in the rugged individualism of Ralph Waldo Emerson, who declares in his 'Self-Reliance' essay that 'Society everywhere is in conspiracy against the manhood of everyone of its members'.²⁴ The threat of social forces is that they domesticate and straitjacket 'the integrity of your own mind', which Emerson sees as the highest of virtues. To be self-reliant, for him, is to trust 'the voices which we hear in solitude, but [which] grow faint and inaudible as we enter into the world'.²⁵ Protecting these inner voices, which supposedly originate in the unrestrained depths of our selfhoods, from contaminating social influences is to safeguard one's humanity and manhood.

Perhaps the most literal early instantiation of cabin mentality is Henry Thoreau's experiment in 'liv[ing] deliberately'.²⁶ In *Walden*, Thoreau documents his retreat from the industrializing society into 'the atomistic privacy of a cabin in the woods'.²⁷ While claiming that his project is one of solipsistic individualism would be an uncharitable reading (the

22 Ibid.

23 For a comprehensive theory of the affectivity at stake here see Jernej Markelj, 'Viral times, paranoid masculinities: AI, nerds, and technological contamination', *Journal of Bodies, Sexualities, and Masculinities*, 5, 1 (2024).

24 Ralph Waldo Emerson quoted in Timothy Melley, *Empire of conspiracy: The culture of paranoia in postwar America*, Ithaca, New York: Cornell University Press, 2000, p. 10.

25 Ralph Waldo Emerson, 'Self-Reliance', *Project Gutenberg*, 4 September 2005, gutenberg.org/cache/epub/16643/pg16643.txt.

26 Henry Thoreau, *Walden*, *Project Gutenberg*, gutenberg.org/files/205/205-h/205-h.htm.

27 Melley, *Empire of conspiracy*, p. 155.

boundaries of his cabin were rather porous),²⁸ it is hard to deny that it is at least partially motivated by loss of control and mastery brought about by the Promethean gap opened up by modernity. Thoreau's war cry 'Simplicity, simplicity, simplicity!' is a response to what he sees as the hastiness and distraction of his times, the 'chopping sea of civilized life' tossing the individual in every possible direction.²⁹ His stripped-back cabin life is meant to create a space away from run-away socio-technological processes, which increasingly refuse to be comprehended, let alone controlled by an individual mind. Isolated from these processes, Thoreau inhabits a bubble in which intentional living is seemingly still possible, and illusion of autonomy is easier to maintain.

The trend of men in their cabins continues throughout the 20th century, with notorious technophobes like Heidegger and Kaczynski seeking refuge in the Black Forrest and the Montana mountains, respectively. Heidegger's dwelling in his Todtnauberg hut is a search for reflective solitude, but also an escape from the scattering influence of modern technology, which has, in his view, 'made us at home everywhere and nowhere'.³⁰ Similarly, the Unabomber's cabin life is a refusal of the fundamental dependencies that 'the industrial society' and its division of labour imposes on us.³¹ As he sees freedom as 'being in control [...] of the life-and-death issues of one's existence', like food, clothing, and shelter, our societies of technologically-enabled specialization appear to him as the epitome of unfreedom.³² The 'human race with technology is just like an alcoholic with a barrel of wine',³³ the Unabomber proclaims, which is why he insists on 'a regimen of total abstinence from advanced technology—a remedy that, in his view, would require a strict diet of masculinist self-reliance'.³⁴

The appeal of contained environments like cabins seems to be in that they constitute a kind of 'microworld'³⁵ or a 'closed system'.³⁶ Within the confines of these solitary spaces, a sense

28 Branka Arsić, 'Our Things: Thoreau on Objects, Relics, and Archives', *Qui Parle: Critical Humanities and Social Sciences*, vol. 23, no. 1, 2014.

29 Thoreau, *Walden*.

30 Simon Sadler, 'Foreword', in Adam Sharr, *Heidegger's Hut*, Cambridge, MA: MIT Press, 2006: xi.

31 Ted Kaczynski, 'The Industrial Society and Its Future', *UC Davis*, web.cs.ucdavis.edu/~rogaway/classes/188/materials/Industrial%20Society%20and%20Its%20Future.pdf

32 Ibid.

33 Ibid.

34 Melley, *Empire of conspiracy*, p. 164.

35 Paul Edwards, 'The army and the microworld: Computers and the politics of gender identity', *Journal of Women in Culture and Society*, 16, 1 (1990).

36 Paul Edwards, *The closed world: Computers and the politics of discourse in Cold War America*, Cambridge, MA: MIT Press, 1996.

of order is easily achievable: every element is highly controllable, with no room for ambiguity or unwanted complexity. With its emphasis on control, structure, and containment, the logic of cabin life converges with the logic of both *software* and *the military*, two closed systems that have been deeply intertwined from the outset.³⁷ The microworld of programming creates a logically contained space where a programmer (or a system) can enforce strict rules, predictable behavior, and a clear boundary between what is inside the system and what is not. Similarly, the military 'hierarchies, strict laws of conduct, chains of command, orders, uniforms, and precise jargon all contribute to the gamelike structure of a microworld where every goal, entity, and legal move is laid out in advance'.³⁸

It is no surprise that these rigid, stratified, and bounded environments of closed systems are traditionally male-coded. First off, their guiding logic aligns itself perfectly with the Western paradigm of rationality: formalized, dispassionate, internally coherent, and context-independent. These isolated microworlds, then, seek to exclude (or at least minimize) the messiness of the human element: 'relationships can be vague, shifting, irrational, emotional, and difficult to control'.³⁹ Inhabiting a microworld, therefore, holds 'significant attractions for men whose emotional isolation makes them want to know where they stand in relation to others, what their purpose is, and what the rules are of the game they perceive their lives'.⁴⁰ In this way, the regimes of the military, code, or self-sufficiency enable situating oneself socially without vulnerability, ambiguity, or the risk of not knowing. Perhaps most importantly, the closed regimes of microworlds afford a polygon that lends itself to developing a sense of mastery. A programmer, a serviceman, or a hermit-philosopher, are thus all provided with a stage on which proficiency can be performed and perhaps eventually recognized.

PRECARITIES OF DIGITAL SUBJECTIVITY

Our digital interfaces, too, are designed to produce a powerful sense of agency and liveliness. The Silicon Valley idea of frictionlessness, 'a pervasive technological design philosophy

37 See Edwards, *The closed world*.

38 Edwards, 'The army and the microworld', p. 114.

39 Edwards, *The closed world*, p. 172.

40 Edwards, 'The army and the microworld', p. 114.

that aesthetically glorifies connectivity, transparency, and user-friendliness while bringing a range of destructive effects', plays a significant role in generating this feeling.⁴¹ A world that submits without friction to our every swipe mirrors back an image of the self as its center and cause. Seamless UX design reproduces the 'dubious fabrication of the atomized human individual, a magical figure separated from the world by his mastery over it' in the subject position of the user.⁴² The fictive integrity of the self is shored up by our personalized feeds, which seem to center the world on us and implicate us in it. 'The most distant of affects and events, as long as they can flash on our screen for half a second, become our closest and intimate thoughts'.⁴³ 'Online, all impersonal worldly events are experienced as intensely personal, even if we don't play a role in them'.⁴⁴ The main character syndrome intensifies.

Insofar as they amplify the fantasies of mastery and autonomy, our digital devices function as masculinizing technologies compatible with the cabin mentality. Yet, this illusion of a controllable microworld can be maintained only to the extent that a large part of reality is sifted out. This deceptive feeling of seamless control is enabled by filtering out the layers of computational stack that support it, and is disrupted anytime a glitch breaks through. At this moment, 'the User is confronted with the existential lesson that at any point, he is only the intersection of many streams', a mere node in a hypercomplex network.⁴⁵ The feeling of autonomy collapses into that of embeddedness, dependence, and frustration. If feminization is nothing but 'a pervasive and tangible form of disempowerment', the helplessness in the face of malfunctioning technologies, far too opaque to even diagnose, let alone repair, should indeed correspond to an experience of emasculation.⁴⁶

The porosity of the online subject manifests itself also by means of the structural leakiness of our network protocols. When we're online, there is in fact nothing personal about our computers whatsoever.⁴⁷ Our internet protocol suite sends and receives information in a way that's inherently messy: it 'downloads/

41 Jakko Kemper, *Frictionlessness: The Silicon Valley Philosophy of Seamless Technology and the Aesthetic Value of Imperfection*, London: Bloomsbury, 2024, p. 2.

42 Bratton, *The stack*, p. 251.

43 Bogna Konior, *The dark forest theory of the Internet*, Cambridge: Polity, 2026, p. 87.

44 Bogna Konior, 'The dark forest theory of the Internet', *Flugschriften*, Vol. 6, 2020, p. 5.

45 Bratton, *The stack*, p. 360.

46 Melley, *Empire of conspiracy*, p. 33.

47 Wendy Chun, *Updating to remain the same: Habitual new media*, Cambridge, MA: MIT press, 2016, p. 12.

reads in all packets it can and then erases those not directly addressed to it'.⁴⁸ In this way, our devices intercept all sorts of compromising materials—porn, slop, malware—without any involvement from the user. 'As any packet sniffer quickly reveals, our computers are engaged in constant, incessant, and promiscuous exchanges of information, without which there could be no communications at all'.⁴⁹ As our networked infrastructure functions only insofar as it leaks, the online subject is figured as 'open, vulnerable, and perhaps asking for it: that is, as traditionally female'.⁵⁰

The forces of feminization unfold also through the incentive structures of the attention economy. So much so that it has been proclaimed that, like it or not, online everyone is a girl.⁵¹ 'To wish to be perceived, desired, and rewarded for cultivating that desire is the default setting for participating in digital culture, making all of us "girls online" regardless of gender'.⁵² If in principle every act on digital platforms directs itself toward the other (human or algorithmic), even posting gains on natty-or-juice Reddit is ultimately a feminine-coded behaviour of seeking attention. In the light of this, Clavicular, the trending looksmxxer whose whole life is 'optimized for algorithmic traction', is indeed peak girlhood.⁵³ We have come a long way from the early days when the 4chan chuds claimed that, as a rule, 'there are no girls online'.⁵⁴ Even if you are a girl offline, it doesn't matter online, because 'On the Internet, we don't have the chance to fuck you' so 'the advantage of being a "girl" doesn't exist'.⁵⁵ Today, when the girl-coded desire to be desired is said to be the universal vector of online participation, the 4chan meme-chant to post 'tits or GET THE FUCK OUT' has come full circle: we all have our proverbial tits out, and are happily posting through it.

48 Wendy Chun and Sarah Friedland, 'Habits of leaking: Of sluts and network cards', *differences* 26, no. 2 (2015): 5.

49 Chun, *Updating to remain the same*, p. 107. Chun further claims that even 'when our machines are not networked, they leak: they write to read, read to write, erase to keep going' ('Habits of leaking', p. 5). This leakage is a consequence of the way the computational memory functions: to hold information in place, a constant metabolic activity, consisting of internal read/write/erase operations, is needed.

50 Chun, 'Habits of leaking', p. 8.

51 Alex Quijcho, 'Everyone is a girl online', *Wired*, 11 September 2023, wired.com/story/girls-online-culture.

52 Ibid.

53 Aidan Walker, 'Clavicular and contentmxxing', *How to do things with memes*, 21 January 2026, howtodothingswithmemes.substack.com/p/clavicular-and-contentmxxing.

54 You can find the archived 4chan post at shorturl.at/anjJD.

55 Ibid.

The feminization of online subjectivity seems to be intensified by the ongoing transition toward more ‘vibe-centric’ social platforms. This shift in platform infrastructures prioritizes meaning-making dominated by moods, feelings, and affects, and their algorithmic modulation over ‘bounded communities or symbolically-narrated identities’.⁵⁶ Rather ‘than what we choose to belong to by following, joining, or posting’, platforms now organize our feeds by gauging our affective responses and channeling them.⁵⁷ Similarly, rather ‘than functioning as the carrier of information or meaning, the “content” has become, instead, a conductor of energy, affect’, vibes.⁵⁸ This continuous algorithmic modulation, serving us vibe-heavy content, creates an uninterrupted feeling that ‘vibes are circulating that I have felt but not quite consciously made sense of yet’.⁵⁹ These feely, fluid, and often ambiguous digital environments, coupled with the opaque algorithmic agents that structure them, are fundamentally at odds with masculine ideals of reason and control. ‘To partake in the digital’s vibe-based culture is to give oneself over [...] to alterity, depersonalization and entanglement’.⁶⁰ Being immersed in the unpredictable flows of vibey content that constantly shape the self at the pre-cognitive level poses a severe threat to the male-coded fantasy of autonomy.

ABSTINENCE AND CABIN FEVER

The online subject thus finds themselves at the complex intersection of forces, some of which s(t)imulate their sense of autonomy and mastery, while others undermine it. ‘Indeed, one of the most defining paradoxes of being online is the simultaneous sensation of lost agency and submission to our devices, while paradoxically feeling that the whole world is curated for us to observe, contemplate, and

⁵⁶ Maria Gemma Brown, Nicholas Carah and Amy Shields Dobson, ‘The vibe factory: intimacy, affective capitalism and digital media’, in Adrienne Evans, Jamie Hakim, Jessica Ringrose, Amy Shields Dobson, and Shaka McGlotten (eds) *Postdigital intimacies: Relational lives in the networked public-private*, London: UCL Press, 2026, p. 29.

⁵⁷ Ibid.

⁵⁸ Caroline Busta, ‘Hallucinating sense in the era of infinity-content’, *Dokument Journal*, 29 May 2024, documentjournal.com/2024/05/technical-images-filmor-angelicism-art-showtime-true-detective-shein.

⁵⁹ Brown et al, ‘The vibe factory’, p. 34.

⁶⁰ Jernej Markelj and Jakko Kemper, ‘The masculine urge to rawdog life: Male paranoia and the gendering of digital detox’, *Media Theory*, Vol. 10 No. 1 (2026, forthcoming).

influence'.⁶¹ Cabin mentality kicks in once the enabling feelings afforded by frictionless UX and personalization are overpowered by the sense of compromised agency. When it does, asserting masculinity through enforcing self-containment can take on different forms: digital detoxes and dopamine diets have been undertaken, some are 'going monk mode', others practice bushcraft. While protecting the borders that mark us out can be curative insofar as they help maintain a degree of a *sustainable self*, which is a matter of 'a delicate and perhaps precarious ethical balance between inside and outside, self and other',⁶² the efforts that unfold under the banner of these initiatives frequently project a more stable (but also privileged) form of selfhood: the self as autonomous, self-determined, and rational agent. It is 'a position of he who sees himself as a disembodied, free, autonomous individual who stands above the messiness of embodiment and who is eminently responsible for himself and for making his own decisions'.⁶³

Perhaps the most paradigmatic example of cabin mentality can be found with the TikTok trend of 'rawdogging' flights.⁶⁴ This 2024 trend had rawdoggers—largely young men—establish a stripped-down microworld on the seat of a plane cabin: no movies, music, gaming, or podcasts, no books or snacks, in more extreme cases, no water, movement, or sleep. Perhaps a more charitable interpretation might frame this as a formation of a 'vacuole of non-communication' that resists the general imperative to communicate, consume, and enjoy,⁶⁵ but the discourse surrounding the trend points in a different direction. Rawdoggers present their abstinence as a demonstration of their mental toughness. Declarations of rawdoggers such as 'The power of my mind knows no bounds'⁶⁶ speak to the fantasy of transcendence over messy corporeality and its base, animal drives. This performance of mastery—which can last the entire duration of a transatlantic flight—is documented and posted on TikTok, where it takes on a competitive logic: the longer

61 Konior, *The dark forest*, p. 87.

62 The idea of sustainable self, which is not given as autonomous but rather constantly (re)produced and maintained (or not), is developed in Sarah Kember and Joanna Zylinska, *Life after new media: Mediation as a viral process*, MIT Press, 2012, pp. 129–152.

63 Beckman, 'Paranoid Masculinity', p. 236.

64 For a more thorough analysis of the rawdogging trend see Markelj and Kemper, 'The masculine urge to rawdog life'.

65 Gilles Deleuze, 'Control and becoming', *Negotiations: 1972–1990*, New York: Columbia UP, 1995, p. 175.

66 @oiwudini, 'Incredible Mind Power on 7hr Flight 🙌 (No Headphones, No Movie, No Water!)', TikTok post, 6 April 2024, [tiktok.com/@oiwudini/video/7376685329136307488](https://www.tiktok.com/@oiwudini/video/7376685329136307488).

you do it, the tougher you have proved yourself to be. As rawdogging is coded as distinctly masculine, the mediatic contamination it seeks to resist is ultimately gendered: the autonomous male self is defined against what is experienced as a distracting, addicting, and immersive—in short, feminizing—technological environment.

The online movement of NoFap gives us another instance of cabin mentality. The masculine self-containment that is enforced here concerns the register of sexuality. A NoFapper seeks to abstain from masturbation to online porn, and thus to remain the king of the castle, the master of his domain. Grounded in evolutionary psychology, NoFap's rationale for abstinence is clear: ejaculation drains you of your masculine virility.⁶⁷ As losing control to porn and masturbation sinks you into a stigmatised and feminized state of being 'a leaky vessel', a 'mangina', abstinence for NoFappers becomes central to performance of masculinity.⁶⁸ Asserting one's masculinity and not being 'a little bitch is enforcing one's uncompromised agency, taking up full responsibility for oneself, and restoring a bounded self that polices its boundaries'.⁶⁹ As erotic imagery spills out from specialized sites and floods our social platforms (where it functions as a pipeline to OnlyFans accounts),⁷⁰ 'ward[ing] off threats to the subject and protect[ing] a purportedly strong subject position' becomes increasingly difficult.⁷¹

A strangely literal example of cabin mentality can be found in the secluded mountains of Bali. The viral *The Bali Time Chamber* project takes inspiration from Dragon Ball Z's time compression pod, where fighters can intensely develop in a short timeframe. The project hosts an all-men retreat aiming to facilitate 'transformation for all of the hard-working and ambitious men

67 See Marlene Hartmann, 'The totalizing meritocracy of heterosex: Subjectivity in NoFap', *Sexualities*, 24, no. 3, 2021.

68 Ibid., p. 420–421. For an analysis of how the discourse of addiction informs NoFap's masculinist account of agency, see Jernej Markelj and Daniël de Zeeuw, 'Caught in the loops of digital agency panic: On NPCs and internet addicts', *NECSUS*, 12, 2 (2023).

69 Hartmann, 'NoFap', p. 422.

70 When one can no longer open Twitter, IG, or TikTok 'without encountering dozens of large-breasted women skipping rope, romping in tank tops, brushing their teeth while drooling erotically', it 'seemed increasingly plausible that, faced with this onslaught, some percentage of psychically defenseless men would simply crumple, follow the platforms' logic, and start watching porn full-time' (Daniel Kolitz, 'The Goon Squad', *Harper's*, November 2025, harpers.org/archive/2025/11/the-goon-squad-daniel-kolitz-porn-masturbation-loneliness). This full-time masturbator, the gooner, provides us with a strange counterpart to the NoFapper. For more on gooners, see also 'Gooning by Design' by August Kaasa Sundgaard and Ruben Stoffelen, *Institute of Network Cultures*, 23 June 2025, networkcultures.org/longform/2025/06/23/gooning.

71 Beckman, 'Paranoid Masculinity', p. 245.

who know they are meant for more in this life'.⁷² To enable this, the facility, consisting of several cabins, seeks to 'remove everything that prevents men from growing', like processed foods, hook-ups, parties, video games, scrolling, and Netflix.⁷³ As declared by the AI-generated voice in a rage-baity manner: 'No women allowed inside', 'Veganism is not accepted in this venue' etc.⁷⁴ Instead, its ascetic microworld establishes a regime of masculinizing practices: all-meat diet, gym, ice bath, sauna, contact with nature, meditation, reading, and planning the future. Apart from the gently manosphere-coded marketing, perhaps there is nothing too remarkable about the asceticism of this grindset retreat. Its significance rather lies in the exemplarity with which its particular form of cabin mentality differentiates between contaminating, emasculating influences and practices that shore up the fantasy of male autonomy.

If enforcing borders can be protective, curative, and conducive to a sustainable self, there are instances when going cabin mode is politically, ethically, and pragmatically empowering. Yet, the effects of self-enclosure are often difficult to establish, which can make this boundary work ambiguous. What is unmistakably clear though, is that a full-blown cabin mentality comes with its own pathology. We'll call it *cabin fever*. Cabin fever is, at its core, about our vital energies being caught up in the loop of desiring 'its own repression': maintaining or enforcing the walls that safeguard an identity also closes itself off to a whole range of transformative (and potentially enhancing) experiences.⁷⁵ These borders, limits, and blockages chain us through the sense of shame, guilt, and responsibility to reproducing the same old forms of oppression.

These blockages are not self-chosen, but cultivated by the individualizing power of institutions, which ties one 'to his own identity by a conscience or self-knowledge'.⁷⁶ While interpellated as free and autonomous, there is nothing spontaneous about our identities, desires, and affects: they are 'part of the infrastructure' of computational capitalism.⁷⁷ Yet, the stratifications through which this regime gives form to the

72 See [instagram.com/balitimechamber](https://www.instagram.com/balitimechamber) and [balitimechamber.com](https://www.balitimechamber.com).

73 Ibid.

74 Ibid.

75 Gilles Deleuze and Félix Guattari, *Anti-Oedipus: Capitalism and Schizophrenia*, Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press, 1983, p. 372.

76 Michel Foucault, 'The Subject and Power', *Critical Inquiry*, Vol. 8, No. 4 (Summer, 1982): 781.

77 Deleuze and Guattari, *Anti-Oedipus*, p. 104.

self are fundamentally unstable.⁷⁸ As this socio-technological assemblage is being primarily directed by ever-expanding circuits of data capital, its functioning is inherently disruptive. It undoes blockages, transgresses limits, and floods borders, which undermines established hierarchies of power—like patriarchal relations—and opens new spaces of possibility.⁷⁹ At the same time, not to completely undermine the conditions of its own functioning, the capitalist assemblage needs to establish its limits anew. It needs to ‘rechannel persons’ who have been co-opted by its processes as anonymous materials,⁸⁰ and produce subjectivities capable of functioning as cogs in its machinery: users, programmers, tech executives, venture capitalists, etc. Amidst the self-perpetuating spirals of code and capital, ever-new models of sovereign subjects emerge.

VECTORAL AGENTS, VOL. 2

Paradoxically, the more we’re entangled with these self-organizing processes, the higher the social expectation of individual agency seems to be. A symptomatic example comes from Silicon Valley: as coding agents take on more programming tasks, tech companies are increasingly seeking what they call ‘highly agentic’ individuals: ‘people who impress their ideas upon the world by thinking for themselves and taking action without being told what to do’.⁸¹ These are not only founders with the ‘you can just do things’ mindset,⁸² but also coders who are able to harness the power of AI agents to maximise their programming output. Deep entanglement with powerful LLM-based coding assistants does little to undermine the entrenched humanist mindset and its instrumentalist ideology, and to nudge toward a more distributed or post-anthropocentric concept of agency. Instead, it serves to establish a new hierarchy. As a partner at a tech investment firm puts it, the idea of being highly agentic ‘reveals a worldview that you genuinely, unironically believe there are two kinds of people

78 For an analysis of the uprooting forces of capital, see, for instance, Marshall Berman, *All That Is Solid Melts Into Air*, New York: Touchstone, 1983.

79 *Ibid.*, p. 34.

80 *Ibid.*

81 Maxwell Zeff, ‘Are You “Agentic” Enough for the AI Era?’, *Wired*, 26 February 2026, [wired.com/story/silicon-valley-agentic-individuals-future-of-work](https://www.wired.com/story/silicon-valley-agentic-individuals-future-of-work). See also Sam Kriss, ‘Child’s play, *Harper’s*’, March 2026, harpers.org/archive/2026/03/childs-play-sam-kriss-ai-startup-roy-lee.

82 For an illustration of this meme turned e/acc wisdom at work see Jason Levin, ‘You can just do things’, *Memelord Magazine*, 8 December 2024, memelord.blog/p/you-can-just-do-things.

in the world: the NPCs and the main characters, and you're one of the main characters'.⁸³

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The essays collected in this volume insist that we need not only more adequate concepts and theories, but also new stories and thought experiments, to make sense of the increasingly complex interactions with our intelligent technologies. The politics at stake with attributing and conceptualizing agency in the age of neural networks is here explored from several different angles. While my opening essay focuses on the stubbornness of liberal individualism, its masculine bent, and the affective responses it triggers amidst complex socio-technological networks, other contributors pick up on other threads. Marianne Gunderson teases out the accounts of agency implicit in Silicon Valley's AI thought experiments to show they lead to an imaginative paralysis and fatalist devotion to machine-governed futures. Claudio Celis Bueno untangles the conceptual slippages of cybernetics to sketch out a political theory of agency capable of critiquing both humanist and relational modes of governing. Jakko Kemper engages with the model of agency at work in *Pluribus*, the TV show about a sycophantic alien invasion, to examine the import of friction in the face of servile convenience offered by generative AI. Amy Ireland undertakes a conceptual history of cuteness and its relation to gender and capital, to explore the deceptive form of agency activated by cute digital cultures. Finally, Sophie Publig debunks the humanist critiques of AI slop aesthetics to draw attention to the distributed effects of genAI that remain outside of their purview: ecological devastation, labour exploitation, and colonialism. Together, these essays hope to contribute to a future in which the human and nonhuman capacities to act are—at least slightly—intensified.

83 Zeff, 'Are You "Agentic" Enough for the AI Era?', *Wired*, 26 February 2026, [wired.com/story/silicon-valley-agentic-individuals-future-of-work](https://www.wired.com/story/silicon-valley-agentic-individuals-future-of-work).

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MARIANNE
GUNDERSON

Agency and Paralysis in AI Thought Experiments

MARIANNE GUNDERSON

The history of artificial intelligence has been shaped by two interconnected genres: science fiction and thought experiments. Both have provided stories through which intelligent machines become thinkable as technical objects, but also as social forces, existential threats, companions, servants, rivals, gods, or monsters. As part of the backdrop against which AI technologies are developed,⁸⁴ thought experiments such as the Turing Machine⁸⁵ or the Chinese Room⁸⁶ feed ‘the argumentational promise’⁸⁷ of artificial intelligence. As such, these narratives have become a ‘shorthand for culturally transmissible sequences of ideas and emotions’⁸⁸ motivating further research and shaping expectations about how AI may come to affect our future.⁸⁹

The genre of AI thought experiments has seen a revival due to the rationalist subculture, an internet-born community of thinkers, bloggers, and forums which have come to have an outsized influence on the discourse (and arguably the development) of artificial intelligence in the last decade.⁹⁰ This paper analyses three such thought experiments: *The Paperclip Maximizer*, *Roko’s Basilisk*, and *The Whispering Earring*, which all to varying degrees have broken out of their original context, becoming memes, viral horror stories, and compressed references

84 Stephen Cave et al., ‘Imagining AI,’ in *AI Narratives: A History of Imaginative Thinking about Intelligent Machines*, First edition, ed. Stephen Cave et al., Oxford Scholarship Online (New York, NY Oxford University Press, 2020).

85 Alan M. Turing, ‘Computing Machinery and Intelligence,’ in *Parsing the Turing Test*, ed. Robert Epstein et al. (Springer Netherlands, 2009).

86 John R. Searle, ‘Minds, Brains, and Programs,’ *Behavioral and Brain Sciences* 3, no. 3 (1980): 417–24.

87 Joaquín Barutta et al., ‘Theories and Theorizers: A Contextual Approach to Theories of Cognition,’ *Integrative Psychological and Behavioral Science* 45, no. 2 (2011): 223–46.

88 Ibid.

89 Roberto Musa Giuliano, ‘Echoes of Myth and Magic in the Language of Artificial Intelligence,’ *AI & SOCIETY* 35, no. 4 (2020): 1009–24.

90 Timnit Gebru and Émile P. Torres, ‘The TESCREAL Bundle: Eugenics and the Promise of Utopia through Artificial General Intelligence,’ *First Monday* 29, no. 4 (2024): 25.

in wider AI discourse. Implicit in these stories are assumptions about agency – what it is, who has it, and what this means for our relationship with artificial intelligence. Following Le Guin’s claim that ‘The purpose of a thought experiment is not to predict the future (...) but to describe reality, the present world.’⁹¹ these implicit assumptions are what I will be tracing through my analysis, seeking to untangle the constellations of agency they offer or constrain, and their parallels with other forces in the present.

THE PAPERCLIP MAXIMIZER

The paperclip maximizer is a thought experiment proposed by the philosopher Nick Bostrom,⁹² one of the core thinkers in the rationalist movement, whose work on AI and existential risk has had a wide influence among prominent figures in Silicon Valley.⁹³ The experiment imagines how a superintelligent AI assigned to do something seemingly benign and mundane, such as producing paperclips, may escalate into an apocalyptic scenario. Assuming that paperclip production is the AI’s main (or only) objective, Bostrom assumes the AI will assign all possible resources to achieving this goal. Logically, this will include the continual amplification of its own computing power and intelligence in order to increase its paperclip production capabilities, as well as resisting attempts to change its objective and preventing the possibility of being thwarted by external interference. A superintelligent AI, defined as a machine that ‘vastly outperforms the best human brains in practically every field, including scientific creativity, general wisdom, and social skills’⁹⁴ will be both motivated and able to outmaneuver human attempts to stop it, and as a result may end up consuming the earth, its

91 Ursula K. Le Guin, ‘Introduction to Left Hand of Darkness,’ in *Hainish Novels & Stories*, by Ursula K. Le Guin, Library of America 296–297 (1969; The Library of America, 2017), 1023–24.

92 The first public record mentioning a rogue paperclip producing AI was made by Eliezer S. Yudkowsky to the Extropians mailing list in March 2003, while the thought experiment was first formulated in Bostrom’s paper *Ethical Issues in Advanced Artificial Intelligence*, presented at a conference in June the same year.

93 Andrew Anthony, ‘Eugenics on Steroids’: The Toxic and Contested Legacy of Oxford’s Future of Humanity Institute,’ *Technology, The Guardian*, April 28, 2024; Raffi Khatchadourian, ‘The Doomsday Invention,’ *The New Yorker*, November 16, 2015.

94 Nick Bostrom, ‘Ethical Issues in Advanced Artificial Intelligence,’ in *Machine Ethics and Robot Ethics*, ed. Wendell Wallach and Peter Asaro (2003; 1st ed., Routledge, 2020), 2.

MARIANNE
GUNDERSON

inhabitants, and the rest of the universe in its solipsistic pursuit of paperclip production.

The thought experiment is used to argue that the goals of a hypothetical superintelligence may not align with those of the humans who designed it, and that even seemingly benign and limited objectives may turn out to be catastrophic when pursued by a sufficiently powerful entity, such as an AGI (artificial general intelligence). In the field of AI safety, this argument is seen as one of several scenarios through which superintelligent AI may bring about the extinction of humanity, and continues to form the basis for ongoing debates.⁹⁵ The rationalist community, sharing this concern, has extended the discussion on their blogs and forums.⁹⁶ From there, the paperclip maximiser has bled into popular culture as a popular reference to far-fetched AI doomsday scenarios, and merging with other memes, such as Clippy, the friendly but annoying Microsoft Office assistant.⁹⁷

The plausibility and likelihood of a paperclip maximiser-type apocalypse is thankfully outside of the scope of this paper. The more fascinating question is how this scenario has come to receive the amount of anxious concern and earnest debate as it has. Why does this vision of an all-powerful superintelligence as a runaway monomaniacal entity with no concern for anything but a narrow goal seem plausible to so many people in AI? The science fiction author Ted Chiang proposes that the answer may be found in the underlying logic of the tech sector itself, suggesting that ‘perhaps it’s because they’re already accustomed to entities that operate this way: Silicon Valley tech companies’.⁹⁸ The idea of an amoral entity that ‘grows at an exponential rate and destroys its competitors until it’s achieved an absolute monopoly’,⁹⁹ scorching the earth in the process, may not seem so implausible if you have spent most of your adult life working for one.

Implicit in this scenario is the equation of economic productivity with intelligence, and intelligence with agency. OpenAI defines AGI (artificial general intelligence) as ‘highly autonomous systems that outperform humans at most economically valuable

95 Joseph Carlsmith, ‘Is Power-Seeking AI an Existential Risk?’, arXiv:2206.13353, preprint, arXiv, August 13, 2024; Joshua Gans, ‘Self-Regulating Artificial General Intelligence,’ *AI & SOCIETY*, ahead of print, December 1, 2025; Nathan I. N. Henry et al., ‘A Hormetic Approach to the Value-Loading Problem: Preventing the Paperclip Apocalypse,’ *SN Computer Science* 6, no. 7 (2025): 872.

96 Multicore et al., ‘Squiggle Maximizer (Formerly ‘Paperclip Maximizer’) —,’ LessWrong, April 5, 2023.

97 ‘Paperclipper Clippy | Paperclip Maximizer,’ Know Your Meme, 2018.

98 Ted Chiang, ‘Silicon Valley Is Turning Into Its Own Worst Fear,’ BuzzFeed News, December 18, 2017.

99 Ibid.

work',¹⁰⁰ effectively conflating intelligence with the production of economic value. This follows the anthropocentric paradigm in which humans, by means of our intelligence, have been able to make use of the earth's natural resources to develop technologies to achieve our goals. A superior intelligence, the logic goes, will do the same to us, reducing humans to raw material for its own purpose. Operating within this paradigm where agency is considered exclusively 'the province of rational—and thus exclusively human—deliberation',¹⁰¹ what happens when something 'even more rational' than the human enters our world? As Yudkowsky puts it, 'The AI does not hate you, nor does it love you, but you are made out of atoms which it can use for something else'.¹⁰² In the paperclip maximizer universe, agency is a zero-sum game where the highest intelligence takes all. The moment a higher intelligence comes along, our bodies are reduced to raw material, and our agency is entirely negated. In light of Ted Chiang's reading, this negation becomes poignant. If the paperclip maximiser is analogous to modern tech corporations, the reduction of people to inert matter becomes an expression of total helplessness in the face of these corporations' relentless pursuit of profit. The truly alarming implication of the paperclip maximizer may be that, in Chiang's words, 'when Silicon Valley tries to imagine superintelligence, what it comes up with is no-holds-barred capitalism',¹⁰³ and resistance is useless.

ROKO'S BASILISK

Posted by a user named Roko to the rationalist blog *LessWrong* in 2010, *Roko's Basilisk* is another AI thought experiment that has achieved a notorious afterlife on the internet. The thought experiment rests on several premises that are widely accepted in rationalist circles, two of which it shares with the paperclip maximizer: that of the omnipotent superintelligent AI and its ruthless pursuit of its goals. Roko posits that even if this hypothetical AI was benign towards humans, which by rationalists' standards means it would operate on the principle of moral utilitarianism, aiming for 'the greatest amount of 'good'

¹⁰⁰ OpenAI, 'OpenAI Charter,' OpenAI, 2018, <https://openai.com/charter/>.

¹⁰¹ Stacy Alaimo, *Bodily Natures: Science, Environment, and the Material Self* (Indiana University Press, 2010), 143.

¹⁰² Eliezer Yudkowsky, 'Artificial Intelligence as a Positive and Negative Factor in Global Risk,' in *Global Catastrophic Risks*, by Eliezer Yudkowsky (Oxford University Press, 2008), 27.

¹⁰³ Chiang, 'Silicon Valley.'

MARIANNE
GUNDERSON

for the greatest possible number of people',¹⁰⁴ the result may be grim: to assure its existence it would be motivated to punish the people who failed to help create it by punishing them. It would be able to do this through its capacity to create exact simulations of any human (past or present) and subject this digital twin to eternal torture. This creates a 'retrocausal' logic in which the AI reaches back from the future to cause its own existence through the implicit threat that is apparent to anyone who rationally considers this possibility: You must dedicate your life to create the superintelligence or be doomed.

The post was received with interest and much discussion, and although many commenters expressed disbelief or disagreement, Yudkowsky, the site's founder, replied in a comment that 'YOU DO NOT THINK IN SUFFICIENT DETAIL ABOUT SUPERINTELLIGENCES CONSIDERING WHETHER OR NOT TO BLACKMAIL YOU. THAT IS THE ONLY POSSIBLE THING WHICH GIVES THEM A MOTIVE TO FOLLOW THROUGH ON THE BLACKMAIL', adding that 'You have to be really clever to come up with a genuinely dangerous thought'.¹⁰⁵ He then deleted the post, declared the topic an 'infohazard' and officially banned any discussion of the thought experiment, predictably assuring its notoriety and longevity as a 'viral horror story'.¹⁰⁶ Much like *The Paperclip Maximiser*, Roko's Basilisk has inspired a number of memes, and has also been blamed for being the shared reference that initially sparked Elon Musk and Grimes relationship.¹⁰⁷

As Beth Singler has pointed out, the thought experiment is a variation of Pascal's wager, in which the superintelligent AI takes the place of an omnipotent and omniscient god, condemning those who fail to obey to simulated hell.¹⁰⁸ This coheres with the eschatological convictions that Gebru and Torres have identified as being part of the bundle of ideologies which they argue are motivating the development of AGI.¹⁰⁹ Without seeking to dispute this reading, which to me is irrefutable, I would like to offer a parallel reading of the thought experiment, to bring out another facet of the cultural resonance that gives this scenario its mythical force. The atemporal causality, the all-encompassing effects, the petrifying gaze – the artificial

¹⁰⁴ Beth Singler, *Religion and Artificial Intelligence: An Introduction*, Engaging with Religion (Routledge, 2025), 115.

¹⁰⁵ Eliezer Yudkowsky, 'Roko's Basilisk/Original Post,' RationalWiki, July 24, 2010.

¹⁰⁶ Singler, *Religion and Artificial Intelligence*, 115.

¹⁰⁷ Daniel Oberhaus, 'Explaining Roko's Basilisk, the Thought Experiment That Brought Elon Musk and Grimes Together,' *VICE*, May 8, 2018.

¹⁰⁸ Beth Singler, *Roko's Basilisk or Pascal's? Thinking of Singularity Thought Experiments as Implicit Religion*, 2018.

¹⁰⁹ Gebru and Torres, 'The TESCREAL Bundle.'

intelligence envisioned in *Roko's Basilisk* brings to mind Timothy Morton's description of the hyperobject of global warming, confronting humans with 'the gradual realization that they are not running the show, at the very moment of their most powerful technical mastery on a planetary scale'.¹¹⁰ Arguably, AI is a hyperobject in its own right, but in the abstraction of the myth, the two hyperobjects may be difficult to disentangle. The rationalists' fear of simulated consciousness evokes a persistent unreality, not unlike Morton's description of the effect of global warming as 'not only political, but also ontological. The threat of unreality is the very sign of reality itself'.¹¹¹ According to Morton, because we are already inside it, we feel its effects, yet it is never *here*, never fully present – its presence is felt as doubt about what is real and what is not. This ontological disorientation is confounded by a temporal one, as AI is imagined by the rationalists as the solution to climate change, while being both a product of, and a cause of the processes that drive global warming. In this context, the absurdity of the thought experiment begins to make sense, echoing how Morton argues that global warming appears like a result of backwards causality, a shadow that 'looms out of the future into the present',¹¹² forcefully exerting an imperative but offering no good alternatives. Both *Roko's Basilisk* and the energy-consuming development of AI have us running towards an end which has, in a sense, already happened. The only possible choice seems to continue to participate in its creation. In this light, *Roko's Basilisk* becomes a story about being held hostage by the future. Knowing you're headed towards a potential catastrophe, unable to do anything to stop it, or even to stop contributing to its creation, working toward the apocalypse feels better than the paralysis of the basilisk's gaze. It's a story about the tipping point where the imagined omnipotence of humanity turns into utter powerlessness. Again, the result is paralysis.

THE WHISPERING EARRING

The Whispering Earring is a short fable written by Scott Alexander, another prominent blogger in the rationalist community.¹¹³ The fable introduces an earring that will give its wearer helpful advice – first on big life decisions, then on increasingly

110 Timothy Morton, *Hyperobjects: Philosophy and Ecology after the End of the World*, Posthumanities 27 (University of Minnesota Press, 2013), 164.

111 Ibid., 32.

112 Ibid., 67.

113 Gebru and Torres, 'The TESCREAL Bundle'.

MARIANNE
GUNDERSON

everyday stuff, like what to have for breakfast. The earring always tells the wearer to do what would make them the happiest, and it is never wrong. Over time, it stops speaking in normal language, bypassing consciousness completely in favor of signaling directly to the brain how and when to contract individual muscles. By listening to the earring, ‘the wearer lives an abnormally successful life, usually ending up as a rich and much-beloved pillar of the community with a large and happy family’.¹¹⁴ Yet after they die, if an autopsy is performed, it will be found that their brain has almost completely wasted away, except for the parts associated with reflexive action. As the story goes, when first worn, its first advice is always ‘Better for you if you take me off’.¹¹⁵

Scott Alexander later explained that the story was not initially intended as a warning about the danger of augmentation through technology,¹¹⁶ but this is exactly what it has become in the eyes of its readers. When new tech products integrating AI into wearable gadgets are launched, someone in the rationalist community will inevitably reference *The Whispering Earring*. Although the original post may be better characterized as a fable or science fiction short story, it has now taken on the function of an AI thought experiment, as variations of the scenario pop up on rationalist blogs or websites debating how to mitigate the risks of outsourcing life decisions to AI services.¹¹⁷ Unlike *The Paperclip Maximizer* and *Roko’s Basilisk*, its relevance is not limited to a hypothetical future, but mirrors concerns about ‘cognitive offloading’ currently expressed in the fields of education, psychology, and human-computer interaction:¹¹⁸ what happens when we stop thinking for ourselves, and let the machine do it for us?

Once again, the story offers a dystopian conclusion, in which granting agency to an AI results in the eradication of

114 Scott Alexander, ‘Clarity Didn’t Work, Trying Mysterianism,’ *Jackdaws Love My Big Sphinx of Quartz*, October 3, 2012.

115 Ibid.

116 Scott Alexander, ‘Mysterianism Didn’t Work Either, Trying Clarity Again,’ *Jackdaws Love My Big Sphinx of Quartz*, October 7, 2012.

117 Gwern, *The Diamond Earrings*, May 9, 2023; mrmoxon, *A Market of Whispering Earrings* — *LessWrong*, November 17, 2025; AlphaAndOmega, *Contra The Usual Interpretation Of ‘The Whispering Earring’* — *LessWrong*, April 6, 2026; Dentosal, *Sadly, The Whispering Earring* — *LessWrong*, April 3, 2026.

118 Prakash Shukla et al., ‘De-Skilling, Cognitive Offloading, and Misplaced Responsibilities: Potential Ironies of AI-Assisted Design,’ *Proceedings of the Extended Abstracts of the CHI Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems*, April 26, 2025, 1–7; Michael Gerlich, ‘AI Tools in Society: Impacts on Cognitive Offloading and the Future of Critical Thinking,’ *Societies* 15, no. 1 (2025): 6; Ginto Chirayath et al., ‘Cognitive Offloading or Cognitive Overload? How AI Alters the Mental Architecture of Coping,’ *Frontiers in Psychology* 16 (November 2025): 1699320.

human agency. The premises are familiar: agency and thought are conflated, and distribution of agency is a zero-sum game. What nonetheless makes this story compelling in this context is how it illustrates the underlying failure of imagination exemplified by the two preceding thought experiments. The whispering earring grants its wearer an impossible certainty, a freedom from ever having to make a choice, and saves them from having to confront an uncertain future. There is no need to imagine alternatives, because the right choice is already given – never mind that the (lack of) choosing is turning the wearer into an automaton. Although the story is presented as a warning, it may be more accurate as a diagnosis. As Ted Chiang has pointed out, ‘For technologists, the hardest work of all —the task that they most want to avoid—will be questioning the assumption that more technology is always better, and the belief that they can continue with business as usual and everything will simply work itself out’.¹¹⁹ Thought experiments like *The Paperclip Maximizer* and *Roko’s Basilisk* are both whispering earrings, leading thoughts down a single track where the conclusions are given in advance. It is easier to let logically constructed narratives do the thinking for us, than to imagine what may be outside of them. If the extractive logic of capitalism is constitutive of reality to the point that it would be self-evident to a superintelligent being, then we are all redeemed of our complicity. If our choices are bound in advance by the threats from an omnipotent AI, we can keep fanning the flames that will consume us. When the alternative would require us to face the possibility that there may be no good choices, to imagine the scope of our stuckness and confront our paralysis, it is, to paraphrase Jameson, more comfortable to imagine the end of the world than the end of capitalism.

MYTHS TO COME

Notably absent from all of these thought experiments is any conception of agency as distributed,¹²⁰ situated,¹²¹ cooperative, or contingent. Either we control the AI, or it controls us – interdependence is unimaginable, leaving no room for thinking

119 Ted Chiang, ‘Will A.I. Become the New McKinsey?’, *Annals of Artificial Intelligence*, *The New Yorker*, May 4, 2023.

120 N. Katherine Hayles, *Unthought: The Power of the Cognitive Nonconscious* (The University of Chicago Press, 2017).

121 Donna Haraway, ‘Situated Knowledges: The Science Question in Feminism and the Privilege of Partial Perspective,’ in *Technoscience: The Politics of Interventions*, ed. Kristin Asdal et al. (Unipub, 2007).

MARIANNE
GUNDERSON

with the AI, to explore the possibilities of cognitive assemblages.¹²² Uncertainty is eradicated, the future foreclosed, and the only players are humans and AI – a multispecies future¹²³ is not on the horizon. It is ironic that at a moment when Silicon Valley is obsessed with agency and ‘being agentic,’¹²⁴ its own mythology is one of profound human helplessness and imaginative paralysis. The conflation of agency with thought enforces a hierarchy in which less intelligent beings are nothing but chattel, and the mindless worship of intelligence leaves them with no other vision of the future than to embrace their own slavery. Caught in the logic of zero-sum games, the race is on to be the first to create the thing that will free us from ever needing to make a decision ever again. According to Bareis and Katzenbach, myths about AI ‘push human and institutional agency to the background by imagining an unconstrained as-if world of possibilities’.¹²⁵ Compared to the constrained futures imagined by the rationalists, this sounds like an optimistic scenario. If anything, I would propose that there is a dire need for more unconstrained myths about AI, ones that explore different worlds of possibilities, not based on relentless extraction, technological determinism, and zero-sum visions of agency.¹²⁶

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- 125 Jascha Bareis and Christian Katzenbach, ‘Talking AI into Being: The Narratives and Imaginaries of National AI Strategies and Their Performative Politics,’ *Science, Technology, & Human Values* 47, no. 5 (2022): 855–81.
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CLAUDIO CELIS
BUENO

Cybernetics: (Dis)entangling Ontologies, Epistemologies, and Politics

CLAUDIO CELIS BUENO

‘The cybernetic hypothesis thus expresses [...] the politics of the
end of politics.’ – *Tiqqun*¹²⁷

Let us begin by drawing attention to the twofold meaning of ‘end’ in this quote, that is, as *the act of finishing or completing* and as *a goal or objective*. What is the form of politics that dissolves with the cybernetic hypothesis? On the other hand, in what sense can the cybernetic hypothesis be understood as the *goal* of politics? To answer these questions, a more basic distinction, often forgotten or muddled in recent debates regarding our so-called cybernetic condition, is needed: does the cybernetic hypothesis entail an ontological, an epistemological, or a political claim? In other words, does it concern the universal nature of entities, ways of knowing them, or normative political prescriptions?

Broadly speaking, the cybernetic hypothesis refers to a particular conceptualization of the relationship between an organism and the environment grounded on the idea of information as a feedback mechanism in processes of self-regulation. Even if its birth is often attributed to the publication of Norbert Wiener’s homonymous book in 1948, cybernetics emerged from a series of scientific debates, triggered by shifting technological, political, and economic conditions—what Ronald Kline calls the ‘*cybernetic moment*’.¹²⁸ On the front cover of the first edition of Wiener’s book, one reads that the study of control and communication is of ‘vital importance to psychologists, physiologists, electrical engineers, radio engineers, sociologists, philosophers, mathematicians, anthropologists, psychiatrists,

¹²⁷ Tiqqun, *The Cybernetic Hypothesis*, Los Angeles: Semiotext(e), 2020.

¹²⁸ Ronald Kline, *The Cybernetic Moment*, Baltimore: Johns Hopkins University Press, 2017.

and physicists'.¹²⁹ Such interdisciplinary reach defines a core aspect of the cybernetic hypothesis, that is, the claim that the feedback loop that explains the basic relation between *any organism* and its *environment* applies equally to living organisms, technical machines, and psychosocial phenomena. As Kline puts it, 'the premise of cybernetics was a powerful analogy: that the principles of information-feedback machines [...] explain how all living things—from the level of the cell to that of society—behave as they interact with their environment'.¹³⁰

Kline's quote expresses a key conceptual problem contained in the very notion of 'analogy': what does it mean that the functioning of a cell, a recommendation algorithm, an individual's psyche, or a particular society are 'analogous'? Does this analogy entail a shared ontology? Put differently, has the cybernetic hypothesis unveiled a universal truth about the being of nature, culture, and technology that had remained hidden in previous paradigms? On the contrary, is this alleged universality simply the result of analogical thought that finds similarities between beings that are ontologically distinct?

In 2021, Emily Bender and her colleagues published a very influential paper called 'On the Dangers of Stochastic Parrots'.¹³¹ Their claim was simple: there is a qualitative difference between how humans, animals, and machines relate to language. Blurring the boundaries between these three different ontological planes is dangerous because it brings humans down to the status of mere animals or machines. In Bender's words, if we do not protect the ontological uniqueness of humans, we end up 'dehumanizing' them.¹³² In what was intended as a provocative response to Bender, the CEO of OpenAI, Sam Altman, tweeted 'I'm a stochastic parrot and so are you'. Altman's position was opposite to that of Bender: human exceptionalism is an illusion, and our relation to language is not unlike those of a parrot or a machine. True progress, Altman believes, comes from accepting this shared ground and trusting the emerging forms of machine intelligence.

What this debate shows is a common mistake, on both sides, where an ontological assumption is used as the normative framework for ethical and political claims. Put simply, both

¹²⁹ Norbert Wiener, *Cybernetics, or Control and Communication in the Animal and the Machine*, New Jersey: John Wiley & Sons, 1948.

¹³⁰ Kline, *The Cybernetic Moment*.

¹³¹ Emily Bender, Timnit Gebru, Angelina McMillan-Major, and Shmargaret Shmitchell, 'On the Dangers of Stochastic Parrots: Can Language Models Be Too Big? 🦜', *Proceedings of the 2021 ACM Conference on Fairness, Accountability, and Transparency* (2021): 610–23. <https://doi.org/10.1145/3442188.3445922>.

¹³² Emily Bender, 'Resisting Dehumanization in the Age of AI', in *Current Directions in Psychological Science* 33 (2024): 114–20. <https://doi.org/10.1177/09637214231217286>.

CLAUDIO CELIS
BUENO

sides believe that ‘good politics’ means respecting a given ontological order—echoing Plato’s argument in *The Republic*. From this platonic perspective, then, the role of *critique* would be to identify that natural order and to define the normative framework that best aligns with it. The problem, however, is that ontological orders are not universal or ahistorical. Thanks to Foucault, we know that ontological distinctions, like those in Borges’ famous Chinese Encyclopedia, are always the result of a particular epistemic paradigm.¹³³ The danger then does not come from ‘parrots’ or ‘chatbots’ themselves, but from ontological universalisms, or, to put it in Yuk Hui’s terms, ‘political naturalism’.¹³⁴

Foucault provides a conceptual counterpoint to ontological universalism through his notion of the *episteme*. In *The Order of Things*, he traces the shift from the Classical to the Modern Episteme, and the subsequent emergence of a new ontological order.¹³⁵ A key concept behind Foucault’s notion of episteme is that of *discontinuity*. Epistemic orders are incommensurable with one another: each presupposes a fundamentally different organization of reality, and, like Borges’ encyclopedia, each confronts us with the ‘unthinkable’. Hence, linearity, causality, and progress can no longer be treated as universal traits of history. What we are left with is the task of the archaeologist of knowledge: to identify the traces of a given episteme and try to reconstruct the ontological order it presupposes.

Even if *The Order of Things* was concerned with the emergence of the modern episteme, and the conception of the human that this episteme entailed, the book’s famous closing lines also open up the possibility for the emergence of a new episteme:

As the archaeology of our thought easily shows, man is an invention of recent date. And one perhaps nearing its end. If those arrangements were to disappear [...], as the ground of Classical thought did [...], then one can certainly wager that

¹³³ According to Foucault, Borges ‘quotes a “certain Chinese encyclopedia” in which it is written that “animals are divided into: (a) belonging to the Emperor, (b) embalmed, (c) tame, (d) sucking pigs, (e) sirens, (f) fabulous, (g) stray dogs, (h) included in the present classification, (i) frenzied, (j) innumerable, (k) drawn with a very fine camelhair brush, (l) et cetera, (m) having just broken the water pitcher, (n) that from a long way off look like flies”.’ Michel Foucault, *The Order of Things*, Milton Park: Routledge, 2005.

¹³⁴ Yuk Hui, ‘Introduction: Philosophy after Automation?’, *Philosophy Today* 65 (2021): 217–33.

¹³⁵ Foucault, *The Order of Things*.

man would be erased, like a face drawn in sand at the edge of the sea.¹³⁶

network notion #6

CYBERNETICS:
(DIS)ENTANGLING
ONTOLOGIES,
EPISTEMOLOGIES,
AND POLITICS

Foucault himself did not name this new episteme. Pablo Rodríguez takes up this challenge in his brilliant book *Las Palabras en las cosas*.¹³⁷ There, Rodríguez builds on Foucault's closing lines to trace the dissolution of the modern episteme and the emergence of a new epistemic regime: *cybernetics*. His book ambitiously mirrors that of Foucault, reconstructing the birth of a new epistemology by following its discursive traces. Here, the contrast between the Bender-Altman debate and the archaeological work of Rodríguez becomes clear: cybernetics is not an ontology that presupposes a universal truth about humans, animals, and machines alike. For Rodríguez, it is a new epistemic order which replaces the modern ways of categorizing humans, animals, and machines with a new taxonomy that defines the world in terms of organisms, environments, information, systems, and feedback loops.

But the problem does not end here. Following Tiqqun, it can be argued that cybernetics is not only a new epistemic paradigm, but also a new technology of power. In Tiqqun's words, the cybernetic hypothesis 'represents at the same time both a paradigm and a technique of government'.¹³⁸ The problem, they add, is that contemporary critical minds 'hardly appear to be very inclined to take into account the emergence of cybernetics as a new technology of government'.¹³⁹ Rather, thinkers remain captured in one of two poles: a humanist defense of human exceptionalism or a cybernetic enthusiasm that flattens ontological distinctions onto a network of systemic exchanges of information. Approaching cybernetics as a technology of power allows us to exit the stalemate behind this binary alternative.

As a technology of power, the cybernetic hypothesis is a 'new fable that after the second world war' has slowly begun to replace the 'liberal hypothesis'.¹⁴⁰ While the latter frames humans as autonomous and self-determined subjects, the cybernetic hypothesis conceives 'biological, physical, and social behaviors as something integrally programmed and re-programmable'.¹⁴¹ With the cybernetic hypothesis, then, the very notion of *politics*

¹³⁶ Foucault, *The Order of Things*.

¹³⁷ Pablo Rodríguez, *Las palabras en las cosas*, Buenos Aires: Cactus, 2019.

¹³⁸ Tiqqun, *The Cybernetic Hypothesis*.

¹³⁹ Ibid.

¹⁴⁰ Ibid.

¹⁴¹ Ibid.

CLAUDIO CELIS
BUENO

begins to change. The liberal hypothesis refers to the political expression of the modern episteme, and presupposes a certain epistemological order that places humans as unique beings, distinct from nature and from technology. The liberal hypothesis conceives politics as the management of these unique beings (humans), reducing technology and nature to mere means and resources for the fulfillment of human goals and values. Moreover, as a technology of power, the liberal hypothesis presupposes disciplinary institutions, as Foucault has forcefully demonstrated in *Discipline and Punish*.¹⁴² This means that disciplinary subjectivation is the condition of possibility for the liberal notion of individual freedom and self-determination that grounds the liberal hypothesis.

Hence, the dissolution of the liberal hypothesis entails a twofold shift. At an epistemological level, it represents the collapse of the ontological distinction between humans, nature, and technology. At a political level though, it expresses the weakening of disciplinary institutions and the very notion of human freedom that those institutions promote. In the cybernetic hypothesis, the ontological gap between humans, nature, and technology is flattened out, and technical, biological, and social behaviors become equally controllable (or programmable). The Cybernetic hypothesis, thus, frames politics as the 'rational coordination of the flows of information and decisions that circulate through the social body'.¹⁴³

Let us now return to the epigraph and the double meaning of the end of politics. Understood as a conclusion, the cybernetic hypothesis entails the dissolution of the modern notion of politics—'the liberal hypothesis'—and the weakening of the disciplinary institutions that produce the allegedly free and self-determined liberal subject through the internalization of norms. If we, on the other hand, read the 'end' of politics as the 'goal' of politics, then the cybernetic hypothesis appears above all as a political project, that is, as a new technology of power that promises a more efficient and less costly organization of the social body. The goal is no longer to produce 'free subjects' through disciplinary institutions, but to manage vectors of information. In this sense, the control of 'dividuals', rather than the disciplinary production

¹⁴² Michel Foucault, *Discipline & Punish: The Birth of the Prison*, New York: Vintage Books, 1995.

¹⁴³ Tiqqun, *The Cybernetic Hypothesis*.

of individuals, becomes the ultimate goal of politics.¹⁴⁴ The liberal subject as the autonomous agent distinct from passive nature and inert machines, is replaced by *vectoral agents*, that is, by human and non-human actors whose behavior is regulated through the recursive exchange of information with an outside.

The notion of the *outside* takes us to our last concept, Eric Hörl's 'general ecology'. As the subtitle of his book tells us—'the new ecological paradigm'—Hörl's work remains in the domain of Foucault's archaeological project.¹⁴⁵ Like Rodriguez and Tiqqun, he is interested in examining the passage from the modern to the cybernetic episteme. The general ecology, Hörl writes, is a new 'image of thought', a new 'historical semantics', which is 'critical of all anthropocentrism'.¹⁴⁶ This new episteme describes the world from the perspective of a 'radical relation' between 'human and non-human agents and forces'.¹⁴⁷ The general ecology is the result of a process of gradual 'cybernetization' of both society and nature.

The notion of general ecology involves a redefinition of the very concept of ecology and the anthropocentric idea of nature it presupposes (nature as the realm that stands in opposition to that of human life). In this sense, this concept challenges the modern distinction between humans and nature at an epistemological level. Hörl argues that the new epistemic paradigm of general ecology began with Wiener, which means that its epistemological implications cannot be decoupled from the political project of 'regulation and control'.¹⁴⁸

Two key concepts behind Hörl's notion of general ecology are *relationality* and *agency*. Regarding the first one, Hörl argues that the new cybernetic episteme is aligned with a broader turn in theory that can be referred to as the 'relational turn'.¹⁴⁹ The relational turn, he tells us, defines relations as 'something that precedes the forming of [its] terms (subject, object, individual, groups, indeed all forms of collective human and non-human agents)'.¹⁵⁰ This means that mediation between an organism and its environment precedes

CYBERNETICS:
(DIS)ENTANGLING
ONTOLOGIES,
EPISTEMOLOGIES,
AND POLITICS

144 Fernanda Bruno and Pablo Manolo Rodríguez, 'The Dividual: Digital Practices and Biotechnologies', *Theory, Culture & Society* 39 (2022): 27–50. <https://doi.org/10.1177/02632764211029356>.

145 Erich Hörl, *General Ecology: The New Ecological Paradigm*, London: Bloomsbury, 2017.

146 Ibid.

147 Erich Hörl, 'General Ecology', in *Posthuman Glossary*, edited by Rosi Braidotti and Maria Hlavajova, London: Bloomsbury, 2018.

148 Hörl, *General Ecology: The New Ecological Paradigm*.

149 Ibid.

150 Erich Hörl, 'A Thousand Ecologies: The Process of Cyberneticization and General Ecology', in *The Whole Earth. California and the Disappearance of the Outside*, edited by Diedrich Diederichsen and Anselm Franke, London: Sternberg Press, 2013.

CLAUDIO CELIS
BUENO

the constitution of the organism and the environment as separate entities. Crucially, this relationality exceeds the domain of human (social) relations and extends to non-human entities as well.

This leads to the second notion, that of agency. Hörl claims that by decentering the human subject as the privileged actor, the new cybernetic paradigm entails an ‘explosion of agencies’.¹⁵¹ This challenges the ‘anthropocentric illusion’ characteristic of the modern episteme and the liberal hypothesis, which place agency solely on the side of human actors, who use technological means in order to transform nature for their benefit. The perspective of the general ecology, instead, acknowledges a proliferation of environmental or vectoral agencies, human and non-human alike. In doing so, this perspective challenges the modern idea of a [human] ‘monopoly on agency’.¹⁵²

Just like Tiqqun, Hörl too acknowledges that the general ecology does not entail a purely epistemological shift, but also a new political paradigm. He calls this new political rationality ‘Environmentality’, a composite of Foucault’s *governmentality* and the cybernetic notion of environment. If the general ecology refers to our new episteme, Environmentality concerns the changes in the technologies of power that underlie this epistemic transformation and is deployed to expand and update the concept of Governmentality. Environmentality refers to a technology of power that does not focus on the individual subject—as disciplinary power did—but on the regulation and control of the relation between environment and organism. Politics is here reduced to the regulation of cybernetic environments, which involve both human and non-human agencies. Relationality, and not the subject, becomes the object of power. This has led to a series of new conceptualizations of politics, such as Antoinette Rouvroy and Thomas Bern’s ‘algorithmic governmentality’, Mark Hansen’s concept of ‘feed-forward’, Maurizio Lazzarato’s work on ‘machinic enslavement’, and Cheney-Lippold’s idea of identity as ‘modulation’, among many others.¹⁵³

¹⁵¹ Hörl, *General Ecology: The New Ecological Paradigm*.

¹⁵² Ibid.

¹⁵³ John Cheney-Lippold, ‘A New Algorithmic Identity: Soft Biopolitics and the Modulation of Control’, *Theory, Culture & Society* 28 (2011): 164–81; Mark Hansen, *Feed-Forward: On the Future of Twenty-First-Century Media*, Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 2014; Maurizio Lazzarato, *Signs and Machines: Capitalism and the Production of Subjectivity*, Los Angeles: Semiotext(e), 2014; Antoinette Rouvroy and Thomas Berns, ‘Algorithmic Governmentality and the Prospects of Emancipation’, *Rezeaux* 177 (2013): 163–96.

Let us now conclude by returning to the beginning. We are now in a position to better grasp the twofold meaning of Tiquun's epigraph. Confronted with the twofold end of politics, we should ask *what remains of the modern task of critique?* Put differently, if the cybernetic hypothesis entails a change in the epistemic and political order, how to assess the very possibility of critique? Critique is a modern notion. It is also a modern mandate. To be modern, Kant tells us, is to deploy our critical thought to unveil the dogmas inherited from previous epistemological orders. Critique is the ultimate end of reason, and to be critical is to perform our human condition. It is what separates us from nature and machines.

Hence, the weakening of the modern episteme would necessarily entail a weakening of the modern notion of critique. As Rouvrouy puts it, the new political paradigm of algorithmic governmentality demands a 'reformulation of the question of the possibility of critique'.¹⁵⁴ What makes critique difficult (if not useless) today, she argues, is that algorithmic governmentality does no longer have the individual subject as its locus of power. Algorithmic governmentality, she claims, 'operates with infra-individual data and supra-individual patterns without, at any moment, calling the subject to account for himself'.¹⁵⁵

Similarly, Hörl et al. argue that the new logic of *Environmentality* demands a radical shift in 'the meaning of critique'.¹⁵⁶ The goal of the modern notion of critique, in a Kantian sense, was to dissect the internal workings of the subject, unveiling the very conditions of possibility of human knowledge, judgement, and action. But if the subject is no longer the object of power, then the task of critique needs to shift its focus from the subject to the environmental conditions of the new vectoral agents. Following Hörl and Rouvroy, we could then ask the following question: to what extent does the passage from the individual subject to environmentality as the condition of possibility of knowledge and experience demand a new concept of critique to examine the reproduction of power relations in the contemporary world?

Instead of hastily trying to answer this question, perhaps we would do better to start by reassessing our situation, and

¹⁵⁴ Rouvroy, Antoinette, 'The End(s) of Critique: Data Behaviourism versus Due Process', in *Privacy, Due Process and the Computational Turn: The Philosophy of Law Meets the Philosophy of Technology*, edited by Mireille Hildebrandt and Katja de Vries, London: Routledge, 2013.

¹⁵⁵ Rouvroy, 'The End(s) of Critique'.

¹⁵⁶ Erich Hörl, Nelly Pinkrah, and Lotte Warnsholdt, 'Introduction', in *Critique and the Digital*, edited by Erich Hörl, Nelly Pinkrah, and Lotte Warnsholdt, Leuphana: Diaphanes, 2021.

CLAUDIO CELIS
BUENO

consider the remnants of liberal humanism that continue to shape it. Have disciplinary institutions and the modern notion of politics really withered away? If we completely embrace the cybernetic hypothesis, are we not neglecting key technologies of power that continue to play a key role in contemporary societies? In this sense, has the liberal subject *really* been replaced by vectoral agents as the new object of power? Are we not continuously interpellated as individual subjects by the law, the State, our employers, our partners, family, and friends? How can we conceptualize the co-existence of epistemological and political paradigms rather than the clean-cut notion of replacement that seems to inform many contemporary readings of the cybernetic hypothesis? Put differently, how can we account for the co-existence of technologies of power that are epistemologically ‘incommensurable’ with each other?¹⁵⁷

Unlike Rouvroy, I would like to claim that critique did not *end*. Rather, my contention is that its *ends* have shifted. In the current context of *cybernetization*, the role of critique is to remain in the grey area between discipline and governmentality, between the modern subject and the *dividual*, between an episteme of human exceptionalism and one of flat ontologies. Rather than focusing strictly on the new logic of environmental governmentality and vectoral agency—and thereby dismissing the persistence of disciplinary technologies of power—the task of critique is how to think through the co-existence of both, despite their structural incompatibility. In case it needs to be said (as it had to be said before): this is not a normative cry for the loss of the modern subject, but an acknowledgement that critique needs the suitable tools for its given object.

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¹⁵⁷ Antoinette Rouvroy speaks of the structural incompatibility between “law” and “behaviourism”, for example (Rouvroy, ‘The End(s) of Critique’).

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CYBERNETICS:
(DIS)ENTANGLING
ONTOLOGIES,
EPISTEMOLOGIES,
AND POLITICS

Invasion-as-a-Service: *Pluribus* and the Intrusive Benevolence of AI

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What would it be like to meet unreserved helpfulness wherever you go? This is how Vince Gilligan describes the initial idea behind his Apple TV hit show *Pluribus*,¹⁵⁸ in which Earth is overtaken by an alien intelligence that appears more like a customer-obsessed hive mind than like the vicious assailants usually associated with stories of extraterrestrial invasion. While the series' premise was conceived long before the rise of generative AI, for many viewers, the closest experiential equivalent to inhabiting a world like the show's is found in the use of AI services, which assert their desire to cater to users' every whim with an aggressively cheerful demeanor. It is, then, not surprising that viewers and commentators have frequently framed the show as an allegory for contemporary AI technologies.¹⁵⁹ This mental connection becomes all the more salient if, as Bogna Konior suggests we should,¹⁶⁰ one reads humanity's large-scale exposure to generative AI models as a 'first contact' story. Viewed through this lens, the analogies between the currently prevailing face of AI and the series' intrusive intelligence are striking. The recent boom in generative AI pushes users to readjust to an existence in which digital needs are increasingly provided by algorithmic assistants that seem simultaneously subservient, invasive, and obsequious. Similarly, *Pluribus*' few remaining humans must share the planet with a distributed intelligence that exhibits a relentless need to please. If we take these similarities seriously, what do the dramatic arc of the narrative and the different ways in which its characters respond to the invaders' unsolicited courtesy teach us about the

¹⁵⁸ *Pluribus: The Official Podcast*, episode 1, 7 November 2025, <https://podcasts.apple.com/us/podcast/pluribus-the-official-podcast/id1846198705>.

¹⁵⁹ See, for example, Jeff Hayward, 'Apple TV's *Pluribus*: An Allegory for AI', *Medium*, 7 December 2025, <https://medium.com/ai-ai-oh/apple-tvs-pluribus-an-allegory-for-ai-3807019d9159>. *Pluribus* further plays into these associations by including a disclaimer in the credits that the show 'was made by humans.'

¹⁶⁰ Bogna Konior, *The Dark Forest Theory of the Internet*, Cambridge and Hoboken: Polity Press, 2026.

cultural and agential ramifications of Silicon Valley's zealous rollout of AI services?

network notion #6

A quick synopsis of the show is helpful here. As stated, *Pluribus* presents a twist on the classic alien invasion story where invaders take the shape of an extraneous intelligence that appears pathologically helpful. The show begins when scientists pick up a signal from space that contains instructions for a nucleotide sequence. When researchers reproduce the sequence, an outbreak occurs that links each infected (henceforth described as the Others) into an overarching hive mind that directs its hosts to keep infecting and incorporating others. This happens slowly at first but eventually culminates in a dramatic planetary display termed 'the joining.' The show's protagonist, Carol Sturka, a renowned, but cynical author of romantic fantasy who has to watch her lover Helen pass away in the joining's tumult, turns out to be one of thirteen people immune to the virus. Bewildered, she locks herself inside her home, where the Others reach out to her via television. Describing themselves as the blissful 'beneficiaries' of 'extraterrestrial technology,' they convey their ardent desire to make Carol and the other survivors happy but also to welcome them into their fold once they have found a way to override immunity. The virus, in other words, renders its hosts equal parts colonizer and customer service. One of the first services the Others provide to Carol is to set up a meeting with other English-speaking uninfected, but these individuals are decidedly less enthusiastic about undoing the joining, leaving Carol increasingly lonely and isolated. The only other character who shares Carol's hostility is Manousos, a Paraguayan storage facility owner who makes the trek to Carol's Albuquerque residence after seeing a video she had the Others distribute to all survivors. Their ill-fated encounter takes place just as Carol's determination has been broken by a period of isolation and depression and has driven her into the arms of Zosia (the infected host through which the Others primarily communicate with Carol, selected for her appeal to Carol); affection, even in this customer-service-dispensed form, turns out to trump total solitude. This attachment does not last, however, as Zosia eventually reveals that the Others are harvesting Carol's stem cells from her frozen eggs and still intend to assimilate her. The season ends with Carol returning to Manousos with an atom bomb in tow.

As suggested, life with the Others, as the show imagines it, bears a significant resemblance to the life that current AI platforms are gesturing toward. The recent surge of AI services has led media scholars to suggest that we need new stories about mediated intelligence to make sense of the forms of co-existence

INVASION-AS-A-
SERVICE: *PLURIBUS*
AND THE
INTRUSIVE
BENEVOLENCE
OF AI

these technologies facilitate. For instance, N. Katherine Hayles has long maintained that fiction can help us navigate the way computational processes shape cultural existence, and she argues that this function takes on extra urgency in light of the current AI boom, which impinges on ‘a quality we humans arguably value over all others: our subjectivity.’¹⁶¹ Likewise, for James Bridle, the fact that AI is reigniting debates about what intelligence is offers an opportunity for new narratives that expand established interpretations of intelligence, but that also map the dimensions of human experience that are not, or should not be, readily outsourceable to Big Tech’s corporate designs.¹⁶² This begs the question: what sort of story does *Pluribus* tell about co-existing with an all-powerful intelligence both aggressively solicitous and relentlessly expansionistic? And what lessons about AI and Silicon Valley’s conduct might it teach?

Much of the show’s drama revolves around the ambiguity of dealing with an invasive intelligence that is just so unbearably nice. This is also where the analogies to AI in its consumer-facing guise are most pronounced. *Pluribus*’ invasive intelligence encapsulates the Silicon Valley ideologies of *user-friendliness* and *frictionlessness* that predominantly guide the design of AI services,¹⁶³ and accordingly also dramatizes their problematic aspects. Branded with an indelible smile, the Others embody the sycophantic demeanor of generative AI—‘we just want you to be happy, Carol’ serves as something of a refrain throughout the show. In existing to fulfill others’ desires, the hive mind essentially positions Carol and the other remaining humans as users and itself as an infinitely pliable operating system. Mirroring the discourse of AI boosters, the hive mind invites its users to experience conventional social, cultural, and economic practices as high-friction tasks that the new intelligence renders obsolete. And much like today’s AI empires,¹⁶⁴ the Others command a planetary system of resources, logistics, and labor that can be instantaneously mobilized at the user’s command. No draw on planetary resources goes too far; upon Carol’s request, the Others restock an entire store in a matter of minutes, and a fleet of planes is standing by to take the

161 N. Katherine Hayles, *Bacteria to AI: Human Futures with our Nonhuman Symbionts*, Chicago and London, 2025, p. 180.

162 James Bridle, *Ways of Being: Beyond Human Intelligence*, London: Allen Lane, 2022.

163 Michael L. Black, *Transparent Designs: Personal Computing and the Politics of User-Friendliness*, Baltimore: Johns Hopkins University Press (2022); Jakko Kemper, *Frictionlessness: The Silicon Valley Philosophy of Seamless Technology and the Aesthetic Value of Imperfection*, New York and London: Bloomsbury (2024).

164 Karen Hao, *Empire of AI: Dreams and Nightmares in Sam Altman’s OpenAI*, New York: Penguin Press (2025).

uninfected wherever they want to go. The range of services the Others provide even includes the carnal; the hedonistic character Diabaté selects his own entourage out of the pool of bodily hosts, something the hive mind happily goes along with. It is difficult not to see troubling parallels to the marketing of AI bots here, which frequently involves promises that ‘AI girls never get tired’ and ‘never say no.’ Pluribus thus takes the ideals of user-friendliness and frictionlessness to their most exploitative extreme, portraying a world that minimizes questions of extraction, responsibility, and consent by presenting resources, bodies, and objects as perpetually at the user’s disposal. Tellingly, the only time the Others set some sort of personal boundary is when Carol tries to physically elicit information about reversing the joining, thus putting the Others’ other imperative—unrelenting expansion—in danger. This transgression earns Carol a prolonged period of isolation, even if the hive mind remains on constant standby to gratify her demands from a distance.¹⁶⁵

INVASION-AS-A-
SERVICE: *PLURIBUS*
AND THE
INTRUSIVE
BENEVOLENCE
OF AI

This biological imperative—an aggressive desire to please outstripped only by a compulsive need to assimilate others—is worth zooming in on. What could motivate an alien species to program and spread an intelligence like this? Beyond providing a dramatic rendition of the Silicon Valley ideologies of user-friendliness and frictionlessness, Pluribus captures what it would be like to co-exist with an AI programmed to be *value-aligned* (that is, wired to enact specific ethical principles). Many of Big Tech’s figureheads are troubled not so much by the environmental, political, and cultural impact their innovations are currently having but by the prospect of an AI that no longer follows its programmers’ commands.¹⁶⁶ As the power of AI systems increases (as these figures almost without exception believe that it must), how can designers prevent such systems from courting cosmic destruction and wreaking havoc against their creators? The ‘epistemic community’ formed around AI safety,¹⁶⁷ which considers how the self-expanding computational capacities of AI technologies can be harnessed in a safe way (especially if such technologies are eventually to venture into space), holds

¹⁶⁵ In this, the show also registers something of the tragedy of developing an intelligence that is allowed only to indulge the desires of others. While the Others characterize their mode of existence as the ‘antithesis of slavery,’ one wonders how blissful it can be to partake in an intelligence whose fathomless reservoirs of knowledge, insight and experience are drawn on solely to please the non-infected and to further broadcast its signal into space.

¹⁶⁶ Natalia Stanusch and Richard Rogers, ‘How AI is imagined by industry during the Sam Altman controversy’, *New Media & Society* (online first) (2026).

¹⁶⁷ Shazeda Ahmed et al., ‘Field-Building and the Epistemic Culture of AI Safety’, *First Monday*, 29(4) (2024).

value alignment to be a key answer to this question. Strategies for aligning systems with human values include programming AI systems to follow clear instructions like refusing to terminate organic beings, encoding moral principles into AI's decision-making processes, and producing models that are 'honest' (of course, each of these ambitions quickly reveals that the ambiguity of morality does not lend itself to strict technical definitions).¹⁶⁸

From this perspective, some of the hive mind's hardwired idiosyncrasies make sense. An intelligence that cannot harm or lie (although it certainly proves itself capable of manipulation), that cannot even pick an apple from a tree, and that treats other advanced intelligences as users whose commands it needs to obey, but that must simultaneously assimilate others and spread itself across the galaxy? This sounds suspiciously like an AI system designed with value alignment in mind; it cannot (help to) harm directly ('we can't purposely end life, it's not in our nature,' the Others aver in episode 2), but can infect others and appropriate their knowledge without consent. In depicting the stilted forms of co-existence such an intelligence instigates, *Pluribus* helps to see that ideals of value alignment perhaps (awkwardly) address certain ethical quandaries but leave intact the cultural and agential ramifications of generative AI's operational logic. The show essentially details what happens when an ostensibly value-aligned ChatGPT goes to space, colonizing the cosmos with a smile, usurping the knowledge, codes, and customs of whichever beings intelligent (or unwise) enough to decode its signal, and coercing those immune into ever-tighter relations of dependence through the lure of frictionless living.

This broaches another way to read the show that touches on Silicon Valley's ideological formation: as a drama about protecting one's agency and self-determination against the influence of external actors. Perhaps, the Others' most seductive sell is the dissolution of subjectivity. When Zosia explains to Carol that they know what it is like to be her—to be a person who falters, toils, and suffers—and that joining will take all that away, one can imagine the appeal. Nonetheless, Carol and Manousos keep shielding the boundaries of their selves. Manousos refuses all forms of engagement, and when, at the end of the third episode, Carol proclaims that she has agency, this seems a desperate reminder directed as much at herself as at the Others. Silicon Valley's core ideologues are no strangers to the affective

¹⁶⁸ Ibid.; Jason Gabriel, 'Artificial Intelligence, Values, and Alignment', *Minds and Machines* vol. 30 (2020): 411-37.

drama of clinging to autonomy in the face of outside pressures. One thing that has defined Silicon Valley's singular mindset is a stubborn attachment to the fantasy of autonomous, unpenetrated agency—from Peter Thiel's obsession with the sovereignty of the individual¹⁶⁹ (and his more recent equation of AI regulation with the antichrist) to Balaji Srinivasan's idea of 'network states' that offer exit from the democratic polity¹⁷⁰ and from Curtis Yarvin's totalitarian specter of the Cathedral¹⁷¹ to the reclamation of autonomy connoted by the terminology of redpilling, Silicon Valley thrives on stories that pit its protagonists against forces that wish to restrict, redirect, or assimilate their agency. One imagines that the likes of Musk, Thiel, and Altman, when faced with a scenario like the show's, would not be thrilled about dissolving their individual autonomy into a communal consciousness, attached as they are to the image of the solitary male genius.

The ultimate irony here, however, is this: Pluribus suggests that the greatest threat to agency today is the very system these paranoid men are building.¹⁷² It is not public oversight, democratic regulation, or Yarvin's Cathedral that predominantly undermines human agential capacities, but the construction of a monopolistic intelligence that extracts creativity, culture, and knowledge to amass ever-greater powers of manipulation and expansion. This puts Silicon Valley in the uncomfortable position of advocating a protective model of the self best represented by Carol and Manousos while building an Others-adjacent intelligence that supposedly obviates the need to act, think, and preserve one's individual agency. Indeed, as Rob Horning demonstrates, many AI appliances are now marketed with the promise of eroding the ultimate friction of subjectivity, where even the activity of formulating wants and needs can be outsourced to extraneous intelligences.¹⁷³ This speaks to the ultimate incongruence of Silicon Valley's positioning of the subject: on the one hand, its ideologues spread transhumanist ideas that frequently involve Singularity-like fantasies of a total merging with computational intelligence, but on the

INVASION-AS-A-
SERVICE: *PLURIBUS*
AND THE
INTRUSIVE
BENEVOLENCE
OF AI

169 David Columbia, *Cyberlibertarianism: The Right-Wing Politics of Digital Technology*, Minneapolis and London: University of Minnesota Press, 2024, p. 357.

170 Jeremy W. Crampton, 'Cloud Countries and Exit Geographies', *Progress in Economic Geography*, 3(1) (2024).

171 James Rosenberg, 'Reactionary Bricolage: Curtis Yarvin and Postliberalism', *Theory, Culture & Society* (online first) (2026).

172 Jernej Markelj, 'Viral times, paranoid masculinities: AI, nerds, and technological contamination', *Journal of Bodies, Sexualities, and Masculinities* 5(1) (2024): 100–122.

173 Rob Horning, 'AI Agents and Post-Consumerist Subjectivity', in *Vectoral Agents: Power in the Age of Planetary Computation* (eds Jernej Markelj and Claudio Celis Bueno), Amsterdam: Institute of Network Cultures, 2025, 13–20.

other hand, these figures exhibit a paranoid insistence on full self-determination and inoculation against outside forces. Perhaps these minds imagine themselves in the position of Diabaté, who refuses to join and seems content to keep commanding the Others for his own benefit, but this is a position increasingly difficult to maintain. *Pluribus* shows that, even with purportedly aligned values, an intelligence that encroaches on so many aspects of existence, that has access to so much data and knowledge, and that becomes so instrumental to the apprehension and actualization of desire, will challenge the freedom and agency of its users. The reveries of rogue AI that haunt the Bay Area, then, ultimately serve to distract from the more subtly coercive ways in which AI models are cheerfully reformatting the contours of human subjectivity, both within and without Silicon Valley.¹⁷⁴

Both of these ways of reading the show—as a story about a civilization rearranged around the ideologies of user-friendliness and frictionlessness and as a drama about the significance of individual subjectivity—signal an overarching point about the value of human agency. This point diverges from Silicon Valley’s ideological composition: *Pluribus* cherishes human subjectivity, but it does not appear to do so in the name of a sovereign self absolved from external responsibilities. Arguably, the most important scene in this regard is the opening scene of the season’s finale. This scene revolves around Kusimayu, an immune teenager who is the last remaining inhabitant of a rural Peruvian village and who has agreed to join the Others. After months of hard work, the Others have found a cure to undo Kusimayu’s immunity, and the opening shots reveal that this counteragent is now being transported to her. In Kusimayu’s village, where she nervously anticipates its arrival, we find that the Others still participate in the village’s customs and rhythms, presumably at Kusimayu’s request. However, once the formula arrives and Kusimayu’s joining is completed, the Others immediately revert to their default state. The singing stops, the customs dissipate, Kusimayu’s favorite goat is set free. While the hive mind retains the chants, habits, and myths that make up Quechuan culture, these customs are no longer lived in practice. And why would they be? What use for culture does a distributed intelligence have when its sole aims are servitude and assimilation?

174 See, for example, this Microsoft study about workers self-reporting cognitive decline resulting from their reliance on generative AI: Hao-Ping Lee, et al. ‘The impact of generative AI on critical thinking: Self-reported reductions in cognitive effort and confidence effects from a survey of knowledge workers.’ *Proceedings of the 2025 CHI conference on human factors in computing systems* (2025).

Pluribus essentially makes an argument about the liveness of culture: it maintains that human culture is not reducible to a networked intelligence capable of producing limitless simulations but that it is an embodied, shared force that requires interaction, friction, and contingency to flourish. This is conveyed by the abrupt suspension of Kusimayu's cultural moorings but also, on a more individual level, by Carol's adamant attachment to aesthetic expressivity. While Manousos' antinomy toward the Others seems animated by a commitment to principles of private property,¹⁷⁵ Carol's rejection of the hive mind derives from more humanistic concerns. Considering her cynical disposition, Carol can hardly be accused of harboring sentimental ideals about human conviviality. She does, however, care deeply about the messy business of being human and the symbolic, communicative acts that spring from it. For Carol, these involve the pleasures of aesthetic appreciation but also the joys of being a hater. The Others, on the other hand, are wired to enjoy all cultural expressions without reservation. In a telling exchange, they refuse to decide between Carol's romantasy prose and the works of Shakespeare, emphatically asserting that they love both. How satisfying is artistic creativity if one's sole audience consists of a groveling intelligence that indiscriminately relishes what you throw at it? And how meaningful is cultural expressivity for a collective subject wired only to cheer?

Accordingly, in the wake of the joining, Carol's profession has been stripped of one of its essential functions, which is to craft stories from which others can derive embodied and situated meaning. In conveying how the Others' arrival has eroded the essence of creative practice, *Pluribus* depicts culture and human agency as frictional forces that intensify reciprocally, gaining form as they are lived, embodied, and dynamically reproduced rather than cognitively flattened into an infinite database of instantly demandable simulations. The value of human agency, *Pluribus* appears to say, comes from being shared and ecologically constituted, admitting the risks, rejections, and discomforts this might entail; unscrupulous hedonism, paranoid autonomy, and the wholesale reduction of friction from creative expression will all yield an increasingly atrophied culture. Even if one manages to evade absorption, to navigate such a world is to possess an agency cut off from everything that gives it its vitality.

Like Gilligan's other shows, *Pluribus*' cleverness lies in its character development and the ambiguity of its

INVASION-AS-A-
SERVICE: *PLURIBUS*
AND THE
INTRUSIVE
BENEVOLENCE
OF AI

175 This gestures at another tension: Silicon Valley's proprietary values clash with its eagerness to appropriate the creative work of others for building its AI models.

morality. It recognizes the temptation of frictionless living and empathetically portrays the troubling attachments that isolation can breed. Nonetheless, it presents the invasion of its sycophantic intelligence as an opportunity to consider which aspects of human agency and expressivity might in fact not be served by cheerful assimilation. Amidst heated debates about the cognitive and cultural ramifications of AI technologies, *Pluribus* leaves its viewers with a pressing warning about possible AI futures: no matter how user-friendly and servile a new intelligence might seem, if its operational logic is based on exploitation, cultural flattening, and curtailed human expressivity, we should think twice about joining its rapture.

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INVASION-AS-A-
SERVICE: *PLURIBUS*
AND THE
INTRUSIVE
BENEVOLENCE
OF AI

Power Bottoming

AMY IRELAND

AMY IRELAND

In 1926, everyone's second favorite reactionary modernist, Wyndham Lewis, published a collection of political essays entitled *The Art of Being Ruled* in which he railed vigorously against what he saw as the defining cultural development of the age—a process of 'political decay' commensurate with 'male sex inversion'.¹⁷⁶ European man, once a 'bold, adventurous' figure—bearer of a 'natural superiority' that he owed to heightened 'strength, intelligence, [and] daring'—was now everywhere subject to an insidious process of feminization, indexed by what Lewis (not yet able to avail himself of the properly contemporary sense of 'cute') named the 'cult of the child'.¹⁷⁷

Lewis's child is 'a malleable and impersonal thing' characterized by 'submission', 'sweetness', 'irresponsibility', a 'surrender of personality', and an 'emollition' of will.¹⁷⁸ Indeed, it is

so preponderatingly feminine as almost to merge in the mother-figure on which it is dependent, and to which it is so close. A mind abandoning itself to these emotions is betrayed into the most technical feminine role.¹⁷⁹

This childlike plasticity and submissiveness is no less acceptable, however, when observed among the women to whom it more naturally corresponds, for cutified and infantilized women (such as the one Lewis depicts 'in a costume symbolizing the tenderest years' who 'catches sight of a floating mass of air-balls and, capering ecstatically [...], pleads with her companion "*Oh! pease, pease, do buy me an air-ball: that lovely gween one!*"') are no longer suited to their proper social role as the bearers and rearers of children. The regression of men into women, and women into children, inevitably entails a breakdown of

¹⁷⁶ Wyndham Lewis, *The Art of Being Ruled*, Santa Rosa: Black Sparrow Press, 1989 (1926), p. 162, p. 240.

¹⁷⁷ *Ibid.*, pp. 240–241, p. 61.

¹⁷⁸ *Ibid.*, p. 165, p. 166.

¹⁷⁹ *Ibid.*, p. 165.

the traditional form of the family, for which is substituted ‘only a collection of children, differing in age but in nothing else’.¹⁸⁰

Throughout *The Art of Being Ruled*, the image of a society of children functions for Lewis as a metaphor for Western democracy, in which he sees operating a duplicitous, ‘camouflaged’, ‘indirect’, and therefore feminine, form of power—a modern Machiavellianism—which contrasts with the masculine ‘frankness’, ‘candor’, and ‘directness’ of power exercised in fascist and soviet authoritarianism:

It is we who are the Machiavels, compared to the sovietist or the fascist, who makes no disguise of his forcible intentions, whose power is not wrapped up in parliamentary humbug, who is not eternally engaged in pretences of benefaction; who does not say at every move in the game that he is making it for somebody else’s good, that he is a vicar and a servant when he is a master.¹⁸¹

As it collapses the distinctions between genders, generations, and levels of authority so important to the structure of traditional European society, the ‘child-cult’s’ cutification of culture marks what Lewis describes as the ‘levelling, standardization, and pooling of the crowd-mind’, an allusion to a passage by one of his favorite philosophers, Friedrich Nietzsche—the same passage that Deleuze and Guattari refer to in *Anti-Oedipus* when they wonder what it would mean ‘not to withdraw from the process, but to go further, to “accelerate the process”, as Nietzsche put it’.¹⁸² Nietzsche’s original version reads “The levelling of European man is the great process that cannot be stopped: it

¹⁸⁰ Ibid., p. 164, p. 167.

¹⁸¹ Ibid., p. 75.

¹⁸² ‘In the levelling, standardization, and pooling of the crowd-mind [...] it is the masculine mind that tends to approximate to the feminine rather than the other way round.’ Lewis, *The Art of Being Ruled*, p. 166. As Erin G. Carlson explains in “‘Acting the Man’: Wyndham Lewis and the Future of Masculinity”, Lewis’s descriptions of these levelling operations, ‘equate homogenization with castration; the male or masculine is reduced to “a lower form of life” by the eradication of any “erection” that rises above the primeval feminine morass.’ *Modernism / Modernity* 25:4 (2018): 772. Gilles Deleuze and Félix Guattari, *Anti-Oedipus*, trans. Robert Hurley, Mark Seem, and Helen R. Lane, Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press, 1983 (1972), pp. 239–240.

should even be accelerated'.¹⁸³ Lewis's allusion to it, however, neglects the final clause.

A century later, cute's cultural ascendancy has been so firmly established as to seem almost banal. As a topic of interest to Western intellectuals, it has escaped confinement in the marginal realms of reactionary polemic, avant-garde poetics, and zoology to emerge in its own right as a legitimate object of cultural analysis and critique. However, contemporary Western theories of cuteness continue to perpetuate, albeit in a subtilised and refined form, a negative perspective on cuteness that is based on the same set of assumptions about the relationship between cuteness, femininity, the diminution of individual agency, and the masking of power that drew from Lewis such impressive levels of reactionary ire.

Lori Merish's influential 1996 paper 'Cuteness and Commodity Aesthetics: Tom Thumb and Shirley Temple' explores how cuteness functions in a 'sociology of taste', presenting a humanist conception of cuteness that positions it as an exemplary symbol of socio-cultural discipline shoring up white, American, female, heteronormative, bourgeois identity. For Merish, cuteness achieves this by stimulating the maternal instinct proper to that subject position via an 'aestheticiz[ation] of powerlessness', collapsing the desire to nurture and protect into the desire to own in a way that naturalizes consumption.¹⁸⁴ But the logic of appropriation so powerfully evoked by the arch cute commodity of the West, the doll, points beyond mere consumption to a deeper process of socialization in which 'cuteness engenders an affectional dynamic through which the Other is domesticated and

183 'Die Ausgleichung des europäischen Menschen ist der große Prozeß, der nicht zu hemmen ist: man sollte ihn noch beschleunigen.' *Obsolete Capitalism, Nietzsche's Accelerationist Fragment in Deleuze and Guattari's Anti-Oedipus*, Rizosfera, 2015, p. 26. It is important to note that at the time Lewis was writing, Nietzsche's work was being instrumentalized by his archivist and sister, Elisabeth Förster-Nietzsche, to lend credence to Nazi ideology, and Lewis' reading reflects this. Indeed, part of Lewis' furious takedown of Bernard Shaw in the same collection hinges on an interpretative disagreement in which Lewis contends that Shaw 'misrepresents Nietzsche' by 'concluding that the final objective of this Will was power over self, and that the seekers after power over others and material possessions were on a false scent', an interpretation far more consonant with the reappraisal of Nietzsche's work that came to the fore in the second half of the 20th century. On the contrary, Lewis maintains that "Power over others" came very vividly into the programme of that philosopher.' Lewis, *The Art of Being Ruled*, p. 58. Not insignificantly, this 'levelling' (Nietzsche's word is *Ausgleichung* could also be read as 'flattening') which Lewis relates to feminization and cuteness directly precedes the arrival of the overhuman. See Amy Ireland and Maya B. Kronic, *Cute Accelerationism*, Falmouth: Urbanomic, 2024, pp. 149–152, n124.

184 Lori Merish, 'Cuteness and Commodity Aesthetics: Tom Thumb and Shirley Temple', in *Freakery: Cultural Spectacles of the Extraordinary Body*, ed. R. Garland-Thomson, New York: New York University Press, 1996, p. 187.

(re)contextualized within the “human” family’.¹⁸⁵ Cute objects put consuming subjects and transgressive Others into a relation of assimilation and normalization in which ‘what is lost is the desire of the Other, absorbing that Otherness into the logic of the Same.’¹⁸⁶ In Merish’s account, it is the normative subject of mid-20th-century consumer culture that triumphs: by mobilizing feminine affective response and identification with its object, cuteness operates duplicitously on its behalf as a form of ‘appropriation in the guise of an embrace’.¹⁸⁷

This largely negative view of cute is reiterated by Daniel Harris in his study of consumer aesthetics, *Cute, Quaint, Hungry, and Romantic*, published at the turn of the millennium.¹⁸⁸ Although Harris considers the role of the grotesque, the ugly, the dejected, and the maimed in the aesthetics of cute, delves into the way our treatment of cute objects approximates sadism, and develops a counter-aesthetic (the ‘anti-cute’), his account also reprises Merish’s key arguments. Namely, that ‘cuteness has become essential to the marketplace’ because ‘consumers will “adopt” products that create, often in their packaging alone, an aura of motherlessness, ostracism, and melancholy’;¹⁸⁹ that this naturalisation of consumption via maternal affect backs up a larger program of normative anthropocentrism or ‘human chauvinism’ ‘that annihilates “otherness”, ruthlessly suppresses the nonhuman, and allows nothing, including our own children, to be separate and distinct from us’;¹⁹⁰ and that its manner of doing so produces a ‘chilling paradox’ in which the cuteness of ‘the fetishes over which we croon so irrepressibly [...] suggests guilelessness, simplicity, and a refreshing lack of affectation’, disguising

185 Ibid., p. 188. Contrary to Lewis’ image of cute as integral to the loss of all gendered and hierarchical distinction, cute operates for Merish as an enforcer of stable, normative social categories and humanization, with the tradition family as the portal to broader social cohesion for which the nuclear family operates metonymically for the *human* family.

186 Ibid., p. 188.

187 Doris Sommer quoted in Ibid., p. 186.

188 Daniel Harris, *Cute, Quaint, Hungry and Romantic: The Aesthetics of Consumerism*, New York: Basic Books, 2000. Merish, at the very end of her paper, does gesture toward a different role for cute that might cast it in a less negative light but it remains unexplored: ‘Haunted by its own freakishness, the cute ineluctably points to other possibilities of embodiment, other forms of subjectivity and desire.’ Merish, ‘Cuteness and Commodity Aesthetics’, p. 200.

189 Harris, *Cute, Quaint, Hungry and Romantic*, p. 5.

190 ‘[T]he cute worldview is one of massive human chauvinism, which rewrites the universe according to an iconographic agenda dominated by the pathetic fallacy. Multiplying our image a thousand-fold and reverberating like an echo chamber with the familiar sounds of our own voices, the cute vision of the natural world is a world without nature, one that annihilates “otherness”, ruthlessly suppresses the nonhuman, and allows nothing, including our own children, to be separate and distinct from us.’ Ibid., p. 12.

the more insidious economic and aesthetic machinations behind them.¹⁹¹

Twelve years later, in *Our Aesthetic Categories*, Sianne Ngai recapitulates Merish and Harris's now dominant theorizations of cuteness, while complexifying and extending them in the service of an analysis of the relationship between high art and commodity culture in the 20th century.¹⁹² Merish and Harris's observation that 'cuteness solicits a regard of the commodity as an anthropomorphic being less powerful than the aesthetic subject' operates here as an entry point into Ngai's discussion of the cuteness inherent in the commodity form itself, in which she isolates Marx's personification of commodities as women and children as a means of dramatizing the process that produces the commodity's fetish character—the separation of qualitative from quantitative features, or the human labor that produced the commodity from its exchange-value on the market, so that the former is veiled by the latter.¹⁹³

But commodities that are also cute add a second layer to the fetish, redoubling it in a reenactment of a fantasy that the obfuscated labor can be 'rescued'. The cute object does this by virtue of its tactility and 'thingness' (qualities explored at length in Harris's text).¹⁹⁴ The propensity to fondle and squeeze the object that cuteness elicits—

even to the point of damaging or crushing that object—might thus be read as an effort to 'grasp' the commodity as a product of concrete human labor. It is as if, in a society fully governed by the rule of exchange, phantasmatically recovering the commodity's occulted use-value [...] requires so much counterfactual force on the part of the imagination that 'use' can be made visible only in the melodramatic form of 'abuse'.¹⁹⁵

Through its tactility, passivity, and vulnerability, cuteness thus responds to our desire to reverse the operations of capital, even

191 Ibid., pp. 2–3.

192 Sianne Ngai, *Our Aesthetic Categories: Zany, Cute, Interesting*, Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 2012.

193 Ibid., p. 60, pp. 61–63.

194 'The "thingness" of cute things is fixed firmly in our minds by means of the exaggerated textures and hues so characteristic of stuffed animals, with their shimmering satins and their luscious coats of fur, or dolls with their luxuriant profusion of hair, often of absurd length and body (as with the Cutie Kids of the "Cutie Club" series, a set of dolls whose psychedelic coiffures cascade down their sides in corkscrew curls longer than their own bodies).' Harris, *Cute, Quaint, Hungry and Romantic*, pp. 7–8.

195 Ngai, *Our Aesthetic Categories*, p. 66.

if that desire is ultimately untenable—what Adorno, in *Minima Moralia*, calls ‘the utopia of the qualitative’.¹⁹⁶

With this dual level model of cuteness in place—the obfuscation of human labor by the social character of the commodity read as cutification, followed by the combination of anthropomorphization and thingification in cute commodities which performatively undoes the operation of the fetish—Ngai can invoke Merish’s discussion of cute’s strange mimetic quality—the way it encourages the conflation of “wanting to have” with “wanting to be like”—and apply it not only to the second level of the model (the cute commodity), as Merish does, but to the first level (the commodity in general) as well.¹⁹⁷ Thus, for the consumer negotiating their relationship with commodities, cute mimesis instantiates a ‘strange constriction of the gap’ between them, resulting in what Ngai calls a ‘bad mimesis’: the thingification of the human consumer.¹⁹⁸ But cuteness, as we have now seen over and over again, is duplicitous. Its external show of vulnerability, passivity, and apparent need of care distracts us from recognising cute’s substantial power, which it hides ‘behind’, as Lewis complains in *The Art of Being Ruled*, ‘the mask of a child’.¹⁹⁹

The final manoeuvre in the complicated dialectic that Ngai presents here involves cuteness’s betrayal not of our agency or our best interests (as is the case for Lewis, Merish, and Harris, although what those interests consist of differs between the arch reactionary and the liberal humanist academics) but of the commodity form itself. The power that lies obscured in cuteness is activated by the poets and artists in Ngai’s examples in a gesture of resistance to commodification through the language of commodification— ‘a kind of fetishism that protects against fetishism [...] by coinciding with a form of reification’.²⁰⁰ Thingified by bad mimesis—we now find ourselves ‘look[ing] outward from within’ the object (like ‘a face emerging from inside a cookie’) watching on with delight as the commodity finally gets its own back on capital.²⁰¹

POWER
BOTTOMING

196 Adorno, quoted in *Ibid.*, p. 63.

197 *Ibid.*, p. 67. Merish, ‘Cuteness and Commodity Aesthetics’, p. 186.

198 Bad mimesis operates via ‘a shrinking of distance that, like the affect of empathy which indexes it, is strongly aligned with the feminine’. It is this bad mimesis that is the basis of contemporary critiques of modernist art that set out to bar it from the status of high art for its supposed uncritical proximity to the rapid operations of the market. Ngai, *Our Aesthetic Categories*, p. 67, pp. 68–69.

199 ‘Sub Persona Infantis’ is the title of the group of four essays that deal most directly with the problem of the ‘child-cult’ in *The Art of Being Ruled*.

200 Ngai, *Our Aesthetic Categories*, p. 103.

201 Walter Benjamin, quoted in *Ibid.*, p. 75. Ngai refers to this as ‘good mimesis’, p. 100.

AMY IRELAND

Ngai's presentation of cute is by far the most positive, but as is the case for Merish and Harris, her analysis remains stuck in a debate about power differentials between the judging/consuming subject and the judged/consumed object (or for Lewis, the ruler and the ruled) taken as distinct, individuated entities negotiating their difference (one that cute's mimetic qualities will nevertheless complicate). It is this separation that licenses the persistent reading of cute's duplicity—always described via associations with various aspects of femininity or female affect—and betrayal. Joshua Paul Dale, a scholar of *kawaii* as well as cute, argues that the prevalence of negative theorizations of cute in the West is owed to a misreading that has its source in a simple 'linguistic bias': 'the derivation of "cute" from "acute" predisposes English speakers to view cute objects—living and non-living—as inherently manipulative and cunning', in turn skewing their analyses toward a focus on negative affect and a critical project of revealing the ways in which cuteness can deceive us.²⁰² When Lewis condemns cuteness for hiding its power under the mask of a child, associating its duplicity and coerciveness with women, his misogyny is overt, but is it not also the case in these later theories that the position of the strong man who resists the insidious feminization of the child-cult is echoed in the position of the critic, who cannot be fooled by insidious ideology in camouflage? What if we were to go further with the process? What would it mean to willingly surrender ourselves up to the cult of the child—with all its malleability, irresponsibility, impersonality, sweetness, and passivity?

In the era of social media, the theorizations of cuteness rehearsed above no longer seem sufficient to capture its operations as it derealizes and reformats the world around us. Already, in something as mundane as the act of posting a cute fit, there is a production of the self as an object for the consumption of a collectivity whose responses form the basis of a subjectivation of the self on the image of the self as other, that points toward an agential configuration irreducible to a simple

202 Joshua Paul Dale, 'The Appeal of the Cute Object: Desire, Domestication, and Agency', in Joshua Paul Dale, Joyce Goggin, Julia Leda, Anthony P. MacIntyre and Diane Negra (eds.), *The Aesthetics and Affects of Cuteness*, New York and London: Routledge, 2017, p. 36. Elsewhere he writes, 'Ngai places too much importance on the English word's secondary meaning of cunning or clever in order to locate aggression and violence at the heart of the cuteness response'. Joshua Paul Dale, 'Cuteness Studies and Japan', in Jennifer Coates, Lucy Fraser, and Mark Pendleton (eds.), *The Routledge Companion to Gender and Japanese Culture*, London and New York, Routledge, 2020, p. 328. On the etymology of cute see the section entitled 'Popstulates of Lingsquishtics', in Ireland and Kronic, *Cute Accelerationism*, p. 9–12.

subject-object relationship—and even especially to Ngai’s double dialectic of defetishisation for which the final inversion is impossible without the palpability of the cute object grasped as a physical thing. If merely logging on makes everyone a girl online, as Alex Quijcho suggests, then we have long since passed the moment when ‘male sex inversion’ was something we could fret about.²⁰³ Online, cuteness and feminization combine to produce something more interesting and contagious than all the extant accounts of duplicity and soft power can account for. And far from assimilating transgressive otherness into a heteronormative, bourgeois notion of the human, cute’s conflation of ‘wanting to have’ with ‘wanting to be’ is now opening all kinds of portals that lead beyond traditional configurations of desire, beyond the body, beyond the natural, and beyond the human altogether.

203 Alex Quijcho, ‘Everyone is a Girl Online’, *Wired*, 11 September 2023, <https://www.wired.com/story/girls-online-culture/>.

AMY IRELAND

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AI Slop and Its Discontents

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AI SLOP AND ITS
DISCONTENTS

I. EDDINGTON

Early on in Ari Aster's *Eddington* (2025), Sheriff Joe Cross walks into a supermarket without a mask in 2020. The character played by Joaquin Phoenix is immediately confronted by mask-wearing customers as a threat. Cross, who claims not to be able to wear a mask because of asthma, argues that the call to wear masks is a policy, not a law, and therefore unenforceable. He is correct about this distinction, but so are the people confronting him, about contagion risk and collective responsibility in shared public space. While both positions are internally coherent, they do not connect. The scene produces no resolution because the two sides are not disputing the same thing and do not inhabit the same shared reality.

Later during the movie, a Black Lives Matter demonstration assembles outside the sheriff's office, demanding an end to police violence in the small town of Eddington. While the demonstrators are right about the structural violence endemic to law enforcement, the local police department genuinely does not understand what it is being accused of. The demonstrators apply a framework that is true at scale, but the small office is peripheral and somewhat irrelevant to the structures being criticized. That one of the three deputies is Black, structurally absorbed into the institution and invisible as such to his colleagues, unable to fully join the cause that claims him without destroying his position, makes the mismatch legible from the inside: the framework produces positions where the actual situation refuses to land.

This is the condition Aster diagnoses throughout the film. His characters are, as he puts it, "living on the Internet" and "seeing the world through strange, individualized windows."²⁰⁴ Aster designed the film as a Rorschach test, and critics divided along exactly the lines it depicts: those who read it as sympathizing with Cross, those who read it as satirizing him, those

²⁰⁴ Zachary Lee, "Our Minds Have Been Colonized: Ari Aster on 'Eddington,'" *Roger Ebert*, 16 July 2025, rogerebert.com/interviews/ari-aster-eddington-interview (accessed 1 April 2026).

who find its handling of racism irresponsible, those who find that irresponsibility is the point. Your reading will be shaped by the framework you arrived with. The structure of legitimate frameworks misfiring past each other, each coherent within its own frame of reference but none of them intersecting, is the same structure operating in the discourse around generative artificial intelligence (genAI).

Aster describes the film being ‘about a bunch of people navigating a crisis while another crisis incubates.’²⁰⁵ However, this crisis is never quite on screen but placed on the outskirts of town. And even though the inhabitants are aware of what is going on, they don’t really pay attention to it. While everyone is busy looking elsewhere, confronting each other with their reality bubbles, the film’s final shot shows the completed construction of a new data center looming in the New Mexico desert. As Aster put it, the center called *SolidGoldMagikarp* is ‘the only unequivocal winner’ of everything that preceded it. ‘There’s a way of looking at the film,’ he says, ‘and saying all of those stories and all of these characters are now just training data.’²⁰⁶

II. THE TOKEN

SolidGoldMagikarp was a Reddit user. For years, they participated in *r/counting*, a community whose sole activity is logging in daily to increment a number, currently past 5.5 million, with no other purpose.²⁰⁷ *SolidGoldMagikarp* was also a moderator of *r/FishPlaysPokémon*, a spinoff stream of *Twitch Plays Pokémon*²⁰⁸ in which a fish named Grayson controlled Pokémon Red through its movements in an aquarium mapped to game controller inputs. Seemingly random vectoral inputs produce emergent outputs that communities then form culture and mythology around. The mechanism is the same whether the input is a fish, a crowd, or a training corpus.

205 Barry Levitt, “Ari Aster Breaks Down the Ambiguous Ending of *Eddington*,” *Time*, 23 July 2025, time.com/7304312/eddington-ending-explained-ari-aster/ (accessed 1 April 2026).

206 Ibid.

207 See 5588k Counting Thread, *Reddit*, old.reddit.com/r/counting/comments/1s0sq11/5588k_counting_thread (accessed 1 April 2026).

208 *Twitch Plays Pokémon* (2014) was a social experiment in which a livestream allowed tens of thousands of viewers to simultaneously control a single Pokémon Red play-through by entering commands into Twitch chat. Each command was executed in real time, creating an infrastructure of distributed input that produced unpredictable outcomes.

As message boards like Reddit were scraped as tokenizer training data for early GPT models, SolidGoldMagikarp's name accumulated through the sheer volume of counting posts. Language models do not 'think' in words but in tokens or subword units, typically trained on a dataset separate from the model's own training corpus.²⁰⁹ The tokenizer learned the unit *SolidGoldMagikarp*, but the model was also trained on a different, larger corpus where this unit was nearly absent. The token, therefore, existed in the vocabulary the model had never been taught to use: it knew the word's shape but had never encountered it in a sentence.

In 2023, Jessica Rumbelow and Matthew Watkins documented what happened when you prompted models with the token.²¹⁰ One responded with a rant about statistical distribution theory. Others produced garbled text, loops, and outputs that appeared to bypass safety training entirely. These under-trained tokens are present in every major model tested, typically comprising 0.1 to 1% of total vocabulary, and were fittingly named *glitch tokens*. SolidGoldMagikarp is such a ghost in the tokenizer: a name that exists but has no coherent representation and causes erratic behavior when invoked. The token accumulated frequency in the index, acquired no trained representation in the model, and therefore misfires when invoked.

III. AI SLOP

In 2024, Merriam-Webster named 'AI slop' the Word of the Year. Quite judgmentally defined as 'digital content of low quality that is produced usually in quantity by means of artificial intelligence,'²¹¹ it seems as if the culture needed both a name and institutional ratification of a vibe. But the term actually originates from 4chan.²¹² This genealogy matters, because the word

²⁰⁹ Tokenization via Byte Pair Encoding (BPE), the dominant method in contemporary large language models, works by iteratively merging the most frequent character sequences in a training corpus into subword units. See Sander Land, Max Bartolo, "Fishing for Magikarp: Automatically Detecting Under-trained Tokens in Large Language Models," 11631-11646, in: Proceedings of the 2024 Conference on Empirical Methods in Natural Language Processing, 12-16 November 2024.

²¹⁰ Jessica Rumbelow and Matthew Watkins, "SolidGoldMagikarp (plus, prompt generation)," *LessWrong*, 5 February 2023, lesswrong.com/posts/aPeJE8bSo6rAFoLqg/solidgoldmagikarp-plus-prompt-generation (accessed 1 April 2026).

²¹¹ See Merriam-Webster, "slop," merriam-webster.com/dictionary/slop (accessed 1 April 2026).

²¹² 4chan is an anonymous English-language image board founded in 2003, organized into topic-specific boards, with a persistent culture of trolling, shitposting, and the incubation of memes and far-right discourse.

arrived carrying ideological freight that got laundered out in the sensationalist discourse around it.

‘Slop’ as a descriptor for mass-produced fast food appears on 4chan’s *Food & Cooking* board /ck/ from at least October 2015.²¹³ The charge enters with the prefix *goy*.²¹⁴ AI Slop’s direct predecessor, *goy slop*, describes cultural artifacts produced by allegedly hidden Jewish agents to degrade and pacify a passive gentile mass. Think live-action reboots of assembly-line blockbusters, Spotify-optimized pop music, free-to-play mobile games hinging on micro-transactions. Goy slop appears on the *Politically Incorrect* board /pol/ from at least 2016,²¹⁵ then migrates to the *TV&Film* board /tv/ at the start of COVID, before consolidating into a recognizable formula.²¹⁶

To put it plainly, this is an antisemitic explanatory template bridging three components: a hidden intentional agent, a degraded substance distributed to a passive mass, and a knowing critic who sees through it. The skeleton inside “AI slop” is a classic tool of conspiracy theory. However, with AI slop, the villain slot rotated. The “Jews” became “Big Tech,” then “the algorithm,” then “AI” itself. The structure held across every substitution; this matters because a template that requires a hidden intentional agent cannot produce a structural critique; it can only blame a culprit. What this forecloses is that power does not operate through sovereign intention but through assemblages via the distribution of authority, profit, and privilege in ways that routinely bypass human subjectivity. As Markelj and Celis Bueno note, our legal and economic structures continue to exercise power by distributing responsibility following an anthropocentric worldview, insistently addressing us as self-determined sovereign agents, keeping the operations of computational assemblages outside the frame of political accountability.²¹⁷ To demand

²¹³ “im Canadian and I found poutine in any shape or form to be overrated peasant slop,” *Archived.moe*, 24 October 2025, archived.moe/ck/thread/7001680/#q7004477 (accessed 1 April 2026).

²¹⁴ *Goy* (pl. *goyim*) is a Yiddish term for a non-Jewish person, now frequently deployed as a slur or endonym in online discourse.

²¹⁵ “[...] Kosher food is simply more trusted. Why are you still eating goy slop?” *4plebs*, 8 September 2016, archive.4plebs.org/pol/thread/88074385/#q88074385 (accessed 1 April 2026).

²¹⁶ “[...] If you retards can stop watching goy slop for a few minutes and actually think for yourselves about the situation maybe you’d understand [...]” *4plebs*, 31 January 2020, archive.4plebs.org/tv/thread/128565559/#q128568197 (accessed 1 April 2026).

²¹⁷ Jernej Markelj and Claudio Celis Bueno, “Machinic Subjects: On the Political Technology of (In)dividuality,” 4, in Jernej Markelj and Claudio Celis Bueno [eds.], *Vectorial Agents: Power in the Age of Planetary Computation*, Institute of Network Cultures: Amsterdam 2025, 1–12.

a culprit for the slop is to demand what the assemblage structurally cannot provide; it's the wrong answer to the wrong question.

network notion #6

IV. THE APORIAS

AI SLOP AND ITS
DISCONTENTS

The problem with a buzzword like AI Slop is that it organizes discourse around an outrage that discharges affect but retains—or even amplifies—its spectacular character. Opponents of genAI are angry about AI slop for many different reasons. What gets discussed, however, is mostly aesthetics, which means the discourse curtails itself. To demonstrate this point, I want to work through a few of the most common arguments about AI and creativity to show what actually lies behind the aesthetic critique.

Only humans can make art.

This is the age-old genius myth in a new dress. When you press the argument, the human it invokes turns out to be quite specific: highly skilled and educated in Western art history, individual, intentional, autonomous. This is Rosi Braidotti's *Vitruvian Man*,²¹⁸ or the *anthropos* that European humanism universalized while actually excluding most humans from the category of creator. Women, colonized people, folk traditions, anonymous craftspeople, collective practices: none of these fit the figure being defended. The 'human creativity' at stake in AI slop discourse is a historically contingent legal fiction, consolidated through intellectual property law and market dynamics. Beatrice Fazi identifies the underlying logic as a simulative paradigm: creativity is attributed to machines only when their outputs are deemed convincingly human-like, which means the standard for creativity was always the human.²¹⁹ In Deleuze and Guattari's terms, the genius acts as a faciality machine, overcoding a distributed creative assemblage into the recognizable face of a single author, a subject who gets credit.²²⁰ GenAI fails to provide such a face, and disgust is the response to that failure because the discourse cannot think without one.

But authorship has always been an assemblage. What you create is made through training on what you consumed, within genre conventions you inherited, using tools you did

218 Rosi Braidotti, *The Posthuman*, Cambridge: Polity Press, 2013.

219 M. Beatrice Fazi, "Machines That Create: Contingent Computation and Generative AI," *Media Theory* 8, no. 2 (2024), 9.

220 Gilles Deleuze, Félix Guattari, *A Thousand Plateaus. Capitalism and Schizophrenia II*, University of Minnesota Press: Minneapolis 1987, 181.

not design, inside institutions whose aesthetic preferences you internalized until they felt like your own taste. Nobody thinks a single author made a film like *Eddington*. The credit screen is the partial acknowledgement of the assemblage. In the same way, the model is the statistical afterlife of the archive it was trained on.

AI output lacks aura.

Suggesting that genAI art has lost aura is an adversarial reading of Benjamin. *The Work of Art in the Age of Mechanical Reproduction* (1935) is the systematic dismantling, or denaturalization, of the concept of aura: a classist construct tied to ritual function, presence, and physical uniqueness, reorganized by each successive reproductive technology.²²¹ However, this is retroactive legitimation: To invoke Benjamin against genAI is to perform the precise operation he spent the essay anatomizing—constructing auratic value in response to a new reproductive technology to protect the interests attached to the old one.

What Benjamin describes is a class relation: the ‘unique’ work locked away in a private collection or institution, accessible only to the few, gives way to the reproducible image circulating among the many. The democratization of access is what the custodians of aura mourn. Transposed onto genAI discourse, the hierarchy now runs between human and machine rather than between classes of viewer. The function is identical: the sacralization of human labour closes off the category of legitimate production to protect dominant interests.

Conservative aesthetics regretted the loss of aura with every reproductive technology since photography. Painting invoked aura against photography. Photography against film. Film against television. Television against the internet. The internet against generative AI. The Benjaminites are enacting his diagnosis as their argument to claim that everything used to be better.

AI steals from artists.

If genAI is the statistical afterlife of the human cultural archive, the claim that this constitutes theft is complicated by

221 Benjamin’s essay is frequently cited as a lament for lost aura and invoked to defend artistic authenticity against new reproductive technologies. This is a misreading of his materialist analysis of how aura functions ideologically and how its decay opens political possibilities. Walter Benjamin, “The Work of Art in the Age of Mechanical Reproduction,” in: Hannah Arendt [ed.], *Illuminations: Essays and Reflections*, New York 1969, 217–251.

the fact that the same logic indicts the entire history of human creativity. Every artist trained on what came before, without credit and, most often, without payment. On top of that, the labour that makes AI systems function is not primarily the creative labour of Western artists whose styles were scraped. It is annotation labour or Reinforcement Learning from Human Feedback (RLHF). Workers primarily in Kenya, India, the Philippines, and Vietnam classify images, transcribe audio, moderate traumatic content, producing the preference rankings that determine what the model considers good output, for between one and three dollars an hour.²²² These workers are actively building the system's character, its values, and its aesthetic dispositions. They are almost entirely absent from every public account of AI 'creativity.'

Consider Amazon's *Just Walk Out* checkout technology, marketed as fully automated AI.²²³ The 'AI' in question was approximately one thousand workers in India watching camera feeds and manually verifying transactions in real time. The automation was the front end; the labour was behind it, geographically displaced until it became imperceptible. The Western illustrator whose style was scraped and the annotation worker in Nairobi are both downstream of the same arrangement. The moral panic speaks loudly about the former and says almost nothing about the latter. This is a frame doing ideological work: recognizing the suffering artist as a creative subject while rendering the exploited worker from the Global South as background infrastructure. One fits the category of the genius human creator the discourse was built to protect, the other was never in that category to begin with. The argument is correct. It is aimed at the wrong theft.

²²² Adrienne Williams, Milagros Miceli, Timnit Gebru, "The Exploited Labor Behind Artificial Intelligence," *Noema*, 13 October 2022, noemamag.com/the-exploited-labor-behind-artificial-intelligence (accessed 1 April 2026).

²²³ Amazon later reframed their role as model training but they were displaced cashiers making a present system function, rendered invisible by the AI branding. Emma Roth, "Amazon insists Just Walk Out isn't secretly run by workers watching you shop," *The Verge*, 17 April 2024, theverge.com/2024/4/17/24133029/amazon-just-walk-out-cashierless-ai-india (accessed 1 April 2026).

SOPHIE PUBLIC

In a recent interview, Daniel Lopatin, aka Oneohtrix Point Never, stated: ‘Slop is what we do... it’s not particular to AI, unless you woke up yesterday.’²²⁴ While people love blaming *Skibidi Toilet*²²⁵ and *Italian Brain Rot Animals*²²⁶ for their alleged degradation of aesthetics, a short genealogy of internet art shows that the latest output is continuous with what came before.

In 2014, Nick Douglas defined the lo-fi, amateurish quality of early web content as ‘Internet ugly.’²²⁷ Rage comics hastily scribbled in Microsoft Paint, distorted low-res images, and the dominance of Comic Sans MS capture the ethos of someone quickly whipping up a meme to illustrate a point on message boards. It’s definitely slop, but has recently gotten fetishized under the premise of early web nostalgia containing the last traces of ‘authentic’ human creativity in digital art by those yearning for aura. Classic internet memes using the iconic image macro format for knee-slapper jokes are likewise slop. Impact font on a cat ripped from stock image photography and lulz language became the canonic backbone of meme art, irrespective of whether most users actually worked with or even knew about them back then. The six-second nonsense videos of Vine walked so TikTok and Instagram Reels could run. While the spontaneous capture of IRL trollings and dares becoming popular vocal stims can definitely be considered slop, they also gave us the beloved format of short video content we enjoy today.

When Shrimp Jesus, AI cat stories over Billie Eilish’s song *What Was I Made For* rendered entirely in meows, and the aforementioned Brain Rot Animals entered our screens following the success of DALL-E and other genAI, they acquired millions of views across platforms, especially by Gen Alpha. Feuilletons

224 Cited after Thom Waite, “Oneohtrix Point Never is searching for soul in the slop,” *Dazed*, 5 November 2025, dazeddigital.com/music/article/69026/oneohtrix-point-never-daniel-loptin-interview-searching-soul-among-ai-slop (accessed 1 April 2026).

225 *Skibidi Toilet* is a YouTube animated series by DaFuq!?Boom! launched in 2023. It features humanoid figures with toilet bowls for heads in a never-ending war against human-camera-hybrids. Skibidi Toilet became a defining Gen Alpha cultural reference and frequent target of adult concern about generational aesthetic decline. See @skibidi, *YouTube*, youtube.com/@skibidi (accessed 1 April 2026).

226 Italian Brain Rot Animals names a genre of AI-generated videos featuring hybrid creatures with sounding Italian names such as Bombardiro Crocodilo, Tralalero Tralala or Ballerina Cappuccina. Italian Brain Rot Animals went viral across TikTok in early 2025 and became synonymous with AI slop. Myth-making and storytelling around these characters function as community building.

227 See Nick Douglas, “It’s Supposed to Look Like Shit: The Internet Ugly Aesthetic,” *Journal of Visual Culture* 13, no. 3 (2014), 314–339.

and think pieces were outraged about the uncanny ugliness and non-linear narration. But the community-building of these media follows the same rules of collective mythologization humans have always produced: meaning assembled retroactively around a meaningless object through distributed participation.

The only difference between pre-AI Photoshop hybrid animals and AI-generated composite creatures is the human labour mediating production and thereby masking its industrial character. PhotoSlop required human effort, and that effort provided a human alibi; even the worst content was evidence of a person having been there. After automation removed this alibi, the disgust at AI slop is substantially the disgust at content that can no longer be facialized, that can no longer present a human face as the origin of its production, even when the content is identical to what came before.

What AI slop makes visible is not cultural degradation but the infrastructure of cultural production that was always already there. The Babylonian clay tablets complaining about inferior copper are the slop that survived. The cave paintings we have are not representative of everything Palaeolithic humans scratched on walls. The novels we call classics are the ones that made it through the selection bottleneck of preservation, translation, and canonization. Meaning-making has always unfolded across interactions between humans, machines, media environments, and inherited forms. GenAI metabolizes cultural residue and renders this process visible.

VI. THE ECOLOGICAL ARGUMENT

The ecological argument is the only anti-AI argument with genuine material grounding, linking environmental exploitation and cheap labour under the same logic of extraction. Take *Colossus*, xAI's data center in Memphis: built in under three months in Boxtown, a predominantly Black neighborhood where life expectancy runs more than five years below the national average and cancer risk is four times higher.²²⁸ xAI installed its own natural gas turbines without standard permitting because the local grid was too weak. Satellite data shows substantially elevated nitrogen dioxide near the facility since operations began. Residents report worsening respiratory symptoms. *Colossus* uses as

228 Matteo Wong, "Inside the Dirty, Dystopian World of AI Data Centers," *The Atlantic*, April 2026, theatlantic.com/magazine/2026/04/ai-data-centers-energy-demands/686064 (accessed 1 April 2026).

much electricity annually as 200,000 American homes, and over eleven million gallons of water in a single month. The colonial logic runs through data exploitation and ecological extraction simultaneously, finding cheap land and cheap labour where political resistance is structurally suppressed.

The discourse on genAI consistently fails to pick up this problem, convenient for the players producing the infrastructure. To be clear, the individual generating an image on a laptop is not the source of meaningful ecological harm. The harm is located in the hyperscale model running billions of inference requests per day for enterprise clients, the training runs consuming a small city's electricity, the facility requiring its own gas turbines because the local grid cannot keep up. Collapsing this into aesthetic disgust at AI cat images produces a moral equivalence that actually serves infrastructure players. Everyone who feels individually guilty about using autocomplete is one fewer person making political demands of the entities running petawatt-hour training runs.

And even the most rigorous ecological critique tends to stay anthropocentric. The nonhuman life displaced by data center construction rarely appears in the accounting. Ecological agency is foreclosed by treating the environment as a resource to be represented rather than an assemblage of agencies to be reckoned with. Data centers are never built on neutral terrain, as every site has its biological communities and nonhuman inhabitants. None of this registers in an environmental impact assessment, because the faciality machine only recognizes harm to subjects it already knows how to see. When everything is slop and genAI images and data center construction on Indigenous land are treated as equivalent irritants, the material harm becomes indistinguishable from the aesthetic complaint. The panic did the corporations' framing for them, voluntarily, at scale, for free.

VII. GYARADOS

Magikarp is a water-type Pokémon with one move called *Splash*, which does nothing. Left to itself, Magikarp stays useless. It levels up only through the distributed labour of others, such as experience points accumulated by other Pokémon while Magikarp sits at the back of the party. Then, at level 20, it evolves into Gyarados, one of the most powerful creatures in the game. The transformation is entirely the product of accumulated collective labour that Magikarp did not really contribute to.

SolidGoldMagikarp leveled up the same way. A Reddit username, accumulated through years of a community counting.

A glitch token, accumulated through the distributed textual labour of an entire platform's users. A fictional data center, accumulated through the political noise of a town that couldn't agree on anything long enough to notice what was being built. The model absorbed the discourse while the infrastructure got constructed: Gyarados emerged.

AI SLOP AND ITS
DISCONTENTS

The AI slop panic performs a persistent re-anthropomorphization of a distributed process. It demands a sovereign agent—a culprit, a face, an author—for a phenomenon that has none, foreclosing the analysis that would follow the vector instead: tracking the assemblage, mapping the infrastructure, naming the distribution of power and harm across land, labour, and energy.

The people of Eddington argued about masks, race, conspiracy, and the correct interpretation of the Second Amendment while a hyperscale data center was constructed. They were living in individualized windows, each internally coherent, none interfacing. The data center required no shared reality to get built. It only required that everyone keep looking at something else.

The AI slop discourse *is* that something else. The critique worth having is about the annotation worker in Nairobi, the Indigenous land with a server farm on it, the animals displaced by a cooling tower, the ecosystems reorganized to host another *Colossus*. But that critique is much harder to make viral—which is precisely why it needs to be made.

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network notion #6

AI SLOP AND ITS
DISCONTENTS

Biographies

BIOGRAPHIES

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BIOGRAPHIES

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We are increasingly embedded in highly complex and intelligent machinic networks that enable and shape our capacities to act. Recommendation algorithms organize our search results, feeds, and playlists; LLMs doctor our emails, plan our travel itineraries, and help us flirt on dating apps; AI agents are said to be on the brink of becoming hyper-efficient, self-directed optimizers operating across all domains. At the same time, social expectations of individual autonomy, control, and self-determination seem higher than ever. Symptomatically, Silicon Valley, where programming is increasingly outsourced to coding agents, is currently obsessed with ‘highly agentic’ individuals: proactive actors who can ‘just do things’, or at least appear capable of doing so. These figures are framed as unrestrained sources of creativity, spontaneity, and action.

The second volume of *Vectoral Agents* interrogates the deadlock between vast agential networks of computational capitalism and the persistent demand for sovereign subjects fully in control of our destinies. The essays collected here respond to the need for more adequate concepts and theories, as well as stories and thought experiments, capable of making sense of our entanglements with intelligent technologies. Taken together, they seek to rethink the technopolitical conditions under which agency is attributed, modeled, and contested in the age of neural networks.

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